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Gloria Steinem
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Business

- **Qualcomm CEO Cristiano Amon on the Future of AI, China, and More**
  Amon talks to TIME editor-in-chief Sam Jacobs about how Qualcomm became a leader in semiconductors, his trip to China with President Trump, and why he thinks doing business is like fighting in the Colosseum.

Qualcomm CEO Cristiano Amon on the Future of AI, China, and Why He Thinks Doing Business Is Like Fighting in the Colosseum

Those who are bullish about the future of artificial intelligence imagine a day soon when consumer products are finally able to match the potential capabilities of the technology. Among the companies determining that future is Qualcomm, the semiconductor leader whose chips power many of the devices in our lives—from smartphones to automobiles. Cristiano Amon, who marks his fifth anniversary as CEO this summer, is responsible for steering the 41-year-old communications company through a pivotal moment. He recently joined THE CEO MOMENT, our new interview series featuring some of the world's most influential business leaders, to talk about his trip to China with President Trump, where AI is heading next, and how he plans to keep his company competitive.

You've said, I tell my team, we are in the gladiator business. Do you honestly say that?

The reason I use this analogy is because if you're a gladiator, you go to the Colosseum, There's going to be three outcomes: You're going to win, you're going to lose, or you're both going to lose. So you go in, you have a 33% chance of success. If you win, the only thing you accomplished, you can go to the Colosseum one more time.

You've also said that whatever people believe AI is going to be, it's probably going to be bigger. What makes you so sure?

Back in the 2000, people said the internet's going to be big…If you look now, 26 years later, the internet is way bigger than people

thought—by an order of magnitude. It's probably been underhyped in the long run.

You envision a world where humans interact with information that moves beyond smartphones. History makes me question this. So far these devices have failed to take off. Can you convince me now that that future that we've been waiting for is finally here?

I have 40 different designs today of people doing personal AI devices. There are companies doing glasses, which is obvious. There's jewelry, pendants, pens, bracelets, watches…Will all those things pan out? I don't know. I tell you what, right now I'm very comfortable making one bet. Glasses will because this is prime real estate. It's close to my eyes, to my ears, to my mouth.

Is it important for you for Qualcomm to be seen as an AI company?

The future of computing is AI. So by definition, if we're a computing company, we're going to be an AI company. Those things are no longer separable.

You recently accompanied President Trump to his meetings with Chinese President Xi Jinping. What did the trip tell you about the future of the semiconductor supply chain?

I came out of the trip optimistic. There's value in providing semiconductors in American technology stacks to companies in China.

Should Americans be concerned if you sell advanced chips to Chinese companies?

Chips are in everything right now. Chips are in every consumer electronic device and in cars and appliances and everything…It's

pretty easy to understand: Do you like American technology for America? Or do you like American technology for the world?

You present it as if there's one obvious choice, but there are lots of people who would disagree with you.

At the end of the day, it's just math…every leading semiconductor company right now has exposure in business in China. That's a good thing.

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https://time.com/collection/the-ceo-moment/2026/qualcomm-cristiano-amon/

Entertainment

- **Dolly Parton Loved Us All, Darlin'**
  The beloved country-music legend, who has died at 80, saw the light in everyone and sought to bring people together above all else.

Entertainment | remembrance

Dolly Parton Loved Us All, Darlin'

Shima Oliaee is a journalist, writer, and creator of several podcast series including Dolly Parton's America.

Dolly Parton performs in 1978.Bettmann/Corbis

Shima Oliaee is a journalist, writer, and creator of several podcast series including Dolly Parton's America.

Dolly Parton, the beloved country-music superstar known for writing about the lives of regular people in more than 3,000 songs and, in later years, for giving away more than 300 million books to children around the world, has died in Nashville. She was 80.

Parton had recently shared updates about health issues she'd been dealing with since the death of her husband Carl Dean last year, and her representatives told *People* that her death in Nashville came after a "brief battle with cancer." Her nephew and bodyguard Bryan Seaver announced her death in an Instagram video posted to her account on Aug. 25, saying, "Dolly has lived in the light and is in the arms of Jesus, surely met by Carl, her parents, and countless others who have watched her and longed for her to meet them in the heavens."

To her fans around the world, she was Saint Dolly—the American godmother who channeled the sorrows of everyday life into song, wrapping ugly truths in pretty packages. Though she was described by music journalist Robert Oermann as "the Mozart of our times," Parton's larger-than-life hair, excess in rhinestones, surgical implants, and cosmetic work concealed the iron will through which she confronted the day's realities with her craft. Most importantly, she wrote and sang with a woman's voice and heart about topics that uniquely touched her gender. Her songs include stories of stillborn births ("Down From Dover"), suicide ("The Bridge"), shame ("Just Because I'm a Woman"), abuse ("A Gamble Either Way"), adoption ("Doing This for Your Sake"), isolation ("Two Doors Down"), mental institutions ("Daddy Come and Get Me"), and prostitution ("The Bargain Store").

David Gahr—Getty Images

I saw Parton play live in concert during her Pure & Simple Tour in October 2016, a month before the most divisive election in American collective memory, and a year before I began reporting a podcast on her life called *Dolly Parton's America*. At the time, I was looking for someone or something to believe in. On the television and in the news, hatred from both sides of the American political aisle had never seemed more grotesque, but at Parton's show, we all sang together. Parton visited more than 60 cities that summer and fall. Looking back, I can't help but wonder if she knew it would be something of a healing tour, the last of its kind she would do. When I asked Parton what "Dolly Parton's America" meant to her, she responded that her perspective wasn't limited by

borders, that it was Dolly Parton's World: "I just think we need to love one another. I think we need to try a little harder. We need to be a little kinder. We need to be a little smarter. We need to have more love and compassion." The last time I saw her, she told me she was planning a comedy album. She also said that, unlike other artists of her stature for whom posthumously released music has been a point of contention, she'd recorded many more songs of hope she'd put away in a vault, to be released throughout the hundred years following her death.

Parton was a genius from humble origins. Because of them, she remained vulnerable, even relatable, in the public eye. Many wealthy folk prefer to be compassionate from on-high, if at all, never getting their feet wet or hands dirty. Parton rolled in the mud. She claimed she modeled her look on "the town trash whore," whom she thought was "beautiful." She dressed in a way that was her idea of glamour: yellow hair piled atop her head, bright red lipstick and nails, high-heeled shoes, and a tight skirt. "I thought [that woman] was the prettiest thing I'd ever seen," she once said on *Ellen*. "So I grew up to look just like her!"

Once Parton achieved a certain level of fame, her body became a punchline for the late-night circuit. When two male scientists made the world's first cloned sheep, in 1996, they named it after Parton for its "large mammaries." Parton laughed the cracks off with quips of her own ("I don't know if I'm supporting *them*, or they're supporting me"). For the Dolly podcast series, I asked Parton once about whether she thought her look stopped journalists, mostly men in the time she was coming up, from taking her work seriously, or viewing her songwriting as equally important to her work as a performer. She shrugged off the question: "Sometimes you have to look like Jezebel in order to get some angelic things done in the world."

There are countless examples of remarkable women erased by history, but Parton survived her own story long enough to tell it.

Her cycle of resurrections, the highs and lows, didn’t seem to change her much over the years, even as the highs garnered her over half a billion dollars.

Dolly Parton’s early years

Dolly Rebecca Parton arrived on Jan. 19, 1946, in an unheated cabin about an hour outside of Knoxville, Tenn., atop the Smoky Mountains. Her parents paid the doctor who trekked to their home to deliver her with a sack of cornmeal. The fourth of 12 children—as she put it, “Mama always had one on her or in her”—the kids slept three or four to a bed. Their only modern convenience was a battery-powered radio. Her childhood home had no indoor plumbing, electricity, or running water. She later compared it to moving from "the Dark Ages into the light ages."

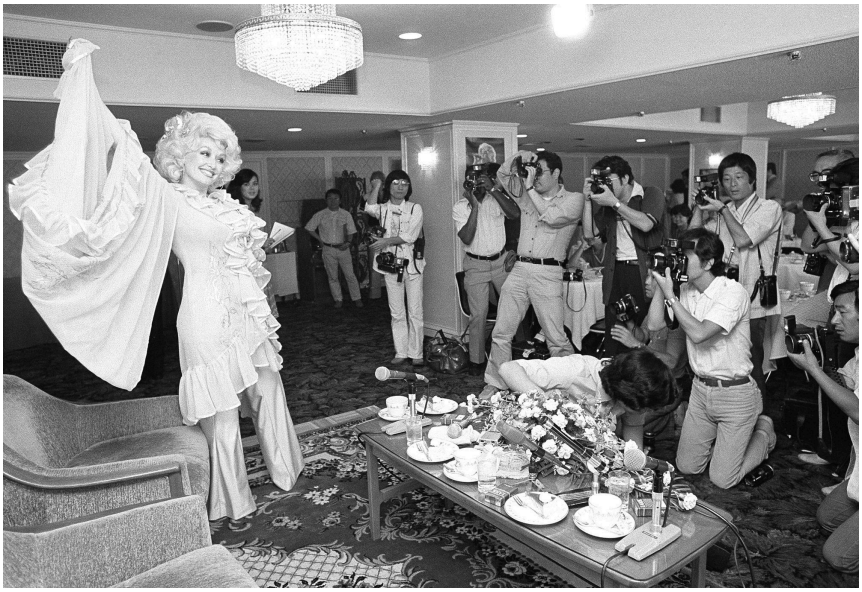
Dolly Parton performs at the Roxy in West Hollywood in 1977.Barr Brandon—MediaPunch/IPX/AP

She grew up surrounded by pines, butterflies, creeks, and neon-green moss. As her father worked from sunup to sundown as a farmer, her mother sang the children Irish and Welsh folk songs “from the Old World,” passed down through the generations. One

day, Parton fashioned a makeshift microphone by putting a tobacco stick into the ground and placing a tin can on top, performing a show of her own. By the age of 5, she had written her very first song, “Little Tiny Tasseltop,” about a corncob doll. By 8, her Uncle Bill Owens, who wrote songs and performed across East Tennessee billed as “Little Billy Earl with the Split Curl,” began to teach her the guitar. They sang together at supermarket openings, rallies, fairs, and talent contests. By age 10, he arranged for her to appear on the *Cas Walker Show*.

Walker was a coon hunter who’d started a local radio-cum-television show to promote his grocery stores. This was Parton’s first big break. At 11, Parton got her first recorded song, “Puppy Love,” co-written with Owens, on the radio, and at 13, she told Johnny Cash she wanted to sing at the Grand Ole Opry. So when an older Opry performer gave up his spot one Saturday night in 1959, Parton got her chance to sing at the historic venue. Cash himself introduced her to the crowd of 2,000. “We’ve got a little girl here from up in East Tennessee,” he said. “Her daddy’s listening to the radio at home, and she’s gonna be in real trouble if she doesn’t sing tonight, so let’s bring her out here!” That night she received three encores.

The day after she graduated high school, Parton took a Greyhound 180 miles to Nashville. For weeks she lived off soups made of ketchup and mustard and food left in the halls of hotels. But these scrappy days quickly paid off. She landed a record deal at 19, and soon after, a husband: a handsome, quiet man named Carl Dean, whom she met at the Wishy Washy Laundromat and would remain married to until his death in 2025. When her record company’s president encouraged her to delay marriage in order to keep her broad appeal to a male audience, she married Dean anyway, in secret. It was the early 1960s. There were obstacles to women owning a home, having credit in their own name, and taking out loans, so Parton moved like perfume, wafting through the world of men while always doing things her own way.



Parton poses for press photographers at a Tokyo press conference ahead of a Japan tour, July 23, 1979.Tsugufumi Matsumoto—AP

When her prophetic single “Dumb Blonde" hit the airwaves in 1966, it captured the attention of a star with the No. 1 syndicated country-music television show in the nation. Porter Wagoner, known for his lavender Nudie suits covered with sequins and rhinestones, had been looking for a new “girl singer.” The pair’s love-hate working relationship kicked off quickly. On her very first stint on the show, Wagoner cut off a shy Parton before she even finished singing. Alternately fighting and writing, they produced hit after hit, and a bolder, louder Parton began to emerge. Wagoner made her a better performer, while she made him a better songwriter. Their partnership also sharpened her already acute sense of humor. She said of her seven years with him, “If I got myself in a spot where it looked like I couldn’t walk my way out of it, or move my way out of it, I would joke my way out of it.”

The Wagoner band worked constantly, and Parton learned how to hold her own onstage and in the studio. Early on in her recording career, she’d been panned as the ditz with “a Minnie Mouse voice,” but she came into a new level of mastery during this phase. While recording “The Mule Skinner Blues” in 1970, Parton took the reins; she sang the first note so long that the band could not begin to play until they followed her lead. The record earned her her first

individual Grammy nomination for Best Female Country Vocal Performance in 1970; she received 11 Grammys over the course of her career.

During her partnership with Wagoner, she wrote many of her signature hits, including “The Coat of Many Colors,” “Joshua,” and both “Jolene” and “I Will Always Love You.” When Parton decided it was finally time to leave Wagoner’s show, he sued her for $3 million, claiming she’d breached their contract. Famously, the lyrics to “I Will Always Love You” served as her way of letting him know how much she appreciated him. To avoid a lengthy legal battle, they settled for $1 million. Parton didn’t have the money, so she paid him in installments over the years.

When Elvis’ manager met with Parton to tell her Elvis would record “I Will Always Love You” if she’d just give up half of the publishing rights to the song, she refused. “I said, ‘I’m sorry, but I can’t give you the publishing,’” she told *W* magazine in 2021. “I wanted to hear Elvis sing it, and it broke my heart—I cried all night.” She attributed this stubbornness to her father’s business sense as a farmer—her songs were like crops, and without owning the harvest, her family would grow hungry.

Parton pictured with some of her stage wigs in Los Angeles on March 10, 1980.Mirrorpix/Courtesy Everett Collection

Parton's life seemed to play out as a constellation of experiences in sync with American history. She entered the working world around the time the first workplace sex discrimination law was passed. Her decision to leave her creative partnership with Wagoner coincided with women leaving unhappy marriages in droves following the passage of no-fault divorce laws. Despite the affection Parton expressed in her famous song, theirs was a messy divorce.

She starred alongside Jane Fonda and Lily Tomlin in *9 to 5*, the 1980 movie based on 9to5, National Association of Working Women, a grassroots movement of female office workers, for which Parton penned an eponymous tune on workplace discrimination. In the film, Dolly plays a secretary who unites with the other women to confront the harassment of their employer Mr. Hart, played by Dabney Coleman. At one point, the women even share fantasies about killing their boss. It was an overwhelming hit. Perhaps Parton's most countercultural act was her decision to work and not have children at a time when Reagan's push for traditional family values took hold of the country.

Parton performs with Kenny Rogers onstage at Brendan Byrne Arena in East Rutherford, New Jersey, Oct. 20, 1988.Gary Gershoff—Getty Images

Over the years, Parton's music evolved from heart-wrenching "sad ass songs" to female-power anthems like "Light of a Clear Blue Morning" to spiritual tunes like "The Seeker" and "He's Alive." In

the mid-‘80s, she opened up about her depression and suicidal thoughts following the end of an “affair of the heart,” family issues, and a negative experience filming *The Best Little Whorehouse in Texas*. She was dealing with a slew of health problems, ultimately undergoing a partial hysterectomy, and as she struggled to lose weight, she put herself on restrictive diets, including a liquid one that made her feel isolated. She documented her loneliness in “Two Doors Down” and started over professionally. She fired her accounting firm, trimmed her band, started her own record label, and founded her amusement park, Dollywood. Over time, she came to embody her moniker, the iron butterfly.

Amid cultural and social upheaval in America, Parton grew accustomed to coming under fire. In 2017, when her Dolly’s Dixie Stampede, a dinner show with teams from the North and South battling, met with protests during a national reckoning regarding monuments glorifying Confederates and racists, Parton dropped the word “Dixie.” Seaver, Parton’s nephew, described Parton’s way of navigating American politics as “dollitics,” noting her habit of evading party-line questions. As she put it, “My daddy was a Republican and my mama was a Democrat, so that makes me a hypocrat.” When she took the stage at the 69th Emmys in 2017 for a *9 to 5* reunion alongside Lily Tomlin and Jane Fonda, she refused to join in their skewering of then-President Donald Trump. Instead, she used her weapon of choice, a tit joke.

If you listen closely, however, her political opinions can be heard in the music. The tracks on her albums include a song based on a tragic true story of a plane filled with deportees crashing into California’s Los Gatos Canyon, one spotlighting the danger of a coal miner’s life and the necessity for workers to unite, and another telling the story of a girl forced into sex work in order to survive. Parton received death threats after contributing the song “Travelin’ Thru” to the soundtrack of the 2005 film *Transamerica*, which tells the story of a transgender woman. She also got threats from the KKK over “Gay Day,” an annual day of visibility for her gay

fanbase. Still, Parton, the self-proclaimed “patron saint of drag queens,” continued to champion the LGBTQ+ community loudly, saying, “If you’re gay, you’re gay; if you’re straight, you’re straight. And you should be allowed to be, you know, how you are and *who* you are.” She once showed up to an annual drag queen competition, only to lose the Dolly look-alike contest to a man in drag.

Dolly Parton’s legacy

Parton poses for a portrait at Dollywood on Oct. 24, 1988 in Pigeon Forge, Tennessee.Ron Davis—Getty Images

Parton liked standing alone. She never jumped on a bandwagon, nor did she punch down. Though she never openly called herself a feminist, in an interview she explained to me that she just shunned labels outright. Her refusal to cast anyone out and her radical acceptance of all kinds of people–queer people, people of color, her outright idolization of the women others called “trash”–in recent years earned her the nickname of “the Great Unifier.” In one of the last interviews for *Dolly Parton’s America*, while looking back on her life, she said, “I don’t practice my faith; I live it.”

Parton was a spiritual leader in a world where political leaders failed us time and again. I talked to a Zimbabwean scholar who

wrote a piece about how the classical artwork of Zimbabwe was less important to many people than Dolly Parton's music, especially the song "Just Because I'm a Woman." It has been on the top of the charts in many countries in Africa for decades now. To get back into her "God space," Parton would leave Nashville for her Tennessee Mountain home, up in the Smoky Mountains where she was born, to fast and begin to come up with new music. Eventually, her 3 a.m. prayers for songs became prayers for creating hope that would last longer than her lifetime.

Reflecting on how her father never learned to read or write, she provided $15,000 scholarships to high school students, and to improve middle school literacy rates in her home county, she gave each child $500 in cash upon graduation. In 1995 she started the Imagination Library, which donates books to children under 5. She invested proceeds from Whitney Houston's towering 1992 cover of "I Will Always Love You" into a Black Tennessean community. When the Gatlinburg fires broke out across Appalachia in 2016, she raised millions of dollars and gave everyone who lost a home $1,000 a month for six months with a final surprise $5,000 check as the program wound down. She made another significant donation in 2024 to support the victims of Hurricane Helene. In 2020, she donated $1 million toward finding a vaccine for COVID, and in 2022, she began offering full college scholarships to every Dollywood employee.

Inducted into the Songwriters Hall of Fame in 2001 and awarded the National Medal of Arts in 2005, an honorary doctorate from the University of Tennessee - Knoxville in 2009, a Grammy Lifetime Achievement Award in 2011, and an honorary Oscar in 2025, Parton piled up accolades as high as the Smoky Mountains themselves. But her greatest feat may have been her devotion to other people, most of them complete strangers. "I just love people," she said. "When I look at the audience I see my family. I see the God light, the goodness, in everybody, even if they can't see it." Perhaps that spirit is how "Jolene" came to be covered more than

400 times—my father first heard it sung by Leila Forouhar in the late 1970s in Iran—or what inspired Nelson Mandela to ask his prison guards at Robben Island to play her music over the loudspeakers. It's a bit comforting to think of Parton's life as a fairy tale, not the culmination of what a single person could do. But her story is a testament to how a person of humble origins can accomplish extraordinary feats, when they pray for, write with compassion about, and take action for others.

And she did this without taking higher status: She remained the butt of the joke, the girl in the wig with a bosom, doing what she believed was right, even while making mistakes. She just tried to do better the next time. In the fax she sent me after the first of what would become 11 interviews, after I came to her with four hours of intrusive questions about some of the hardest moments in her life, she ended her note with: "I had a nice time with you. Hope you got everything that you wanted. I look forward to hearing from you or seeing you again somewhere down the road. Love, Dolly."

What a teacher. I hope we get the lesson.

Parton stands with other 2006 Kennedy Center honorees being celebrated for their contributions to American culture at the State Department in Washington, Dec. 2, 2006. From left are Zubin Mehta, Steven Spielberg, Dolly Parton, Smokey Robinson, and Andrew Lloyd Webber.J. Scott Applewhite—AP

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https://time.com/article/2026/08/25/dolly-parton-remembrance/

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Health

- **Can't Sleep? Try Getting Out of Bed**
  The best way to fall asleep might be to stop fixating on it.
- **Personality Is Linked to Genes, New Study Finds**
  The largest study of its kind has uncovered the genetic links of traits like extraversion and agreeableness.

Health | Sleep

Can't Sleep? Try Getting Out of Bed

mrs—Getty Images

It’s 2 a.m., and you’ve been awake for an hour—staring at the same patch of ceiling, counting the same sheep, and doing increasingly alarming math about how wrecked you’re going to feel tomorrow. Your instinct is to stay right where you are and try harder. Surely sleep will come eventually. And even if it doesn’t, at least you’re resting—right?

Not exactly. The better move, sleep specialists say, is the one that feels most counterintuitive: Get up, leave the room, and do something else. The technique is called stimulus control, and it isn't new—psychologist Richard Bootzin introduced it in 1972, and it remains a cornerstone of cognitive behavioral therapy for insomnia.

Here’s how to do it when you can’t get to sleep, and why it works.

Why lying in bed when you can't sleep makes it worse

The problem begins when you treat sleep like a task you need to accomplish. "Effort is the enemy of sleep," says Shelby Harris, a behavioral sleep medicine specialist in New York. The harder you work at it, the more frustrated and alert you become. People who sleep well, Harris points out, aren't using some secret trick. "They don't really do anything," Harris says. "They just fall asleep."

Sleep, in other words, isn't something you can will into happening, says Michael Perlis, director of the behavioral sleep medicine program at the University of Pennsylvania's Perelman School of Medicine. It's a physiological state, not a behavior you can perform on command.

Watching for sleep to arrive doesn't work, either. People often report that they were close to drifting off, Perlis says, but if you're conscious of being close, you're still awake. After all, how can you consciously monitor yourself becoming unconscious?

There's one more argument for staying put: Even if you aren't sleeping, you figure, at least you're resting. Perlis rejects that one, too. "If rest was any good," he says, "we wouldn't sleep."

How long should you stay in bed before getting up?

People are often told to get out of bed after about 20 minutes awake. But many clinicians have moved away from enforcing that rigid cutoff, partly because there's an obvious problem with it, Harris says: You can't time 20 minutes without looking at a clock—and clock-watching in the middle of the night is a reliable way to become even more stressed about not sleeping.

Instead of watching the clock, notice your mood. The signal is frustration: Your mind is racing, you're getting annoyed, or you catch yourself actively trying to force sleep to happen. "That's the sign that's usually around 20-ish minutes," Harris says. "Get out of

bed, go do something else just to pass the time, and only go back to bed when you think you might be sleepy again."

That doesn’t mean you need to leap out of bed the moment you open your eyes. If you're awake but calm—not spiraling, not straining—you can stay put for a little while. Give yourself a few minutes to see what happens. The time to get up is when your mind starts racing or you notice yourself trying to force sleep.

Why getting out of bed helps you fall asleep faster

Perlis sums up his advice in a simple slogan: “Give up. Get up. Get out.” Giving up means abandoning the effort to fall asleep. Getting up and leaving the room make that decision real: Sitting up, standing, and walking send powerful signals to the body to be awake.

That might sound backward. If your goal is sleep, why would you make yourself more awake? But that’s exactly the point. When you stay in bed trying, Perlis says, you can end up “surfing,” or flickering between wakefulness and sleep without ever feeling as though you slept at all. “You get nothing from surfing,” he says.

Becoming fully awake interrupts that pattern and allows sleep pressure—the biological drive that makes you sleepy—to build. Perlis compares it to putting money in the bank for tomorrow night: Even if getting up doesn’t rescue this particular night, it can improve your odds of sleeping better the next one.

Leaving the bedroom also helps preserve the connection between your bed and sleep. The more time you spend there tossing, turning, worrying, and watching the clock, the more your brain begins to associate bed with wakefulness and frustration. Getting up breaks that association—and, as Perlis puts it, helps “give sleep a chance” a little later on.

What to do in the middle of the night when you can't sleep

Whatever you choose to do once you're out of bed, your goal shouldn't be to do something tiring, Harris says. The activity is simply something to do until sleepiness returns—while keeping you from lying in bed and teaching your brain to associate your mattress with frustration. So pick something you actually enjoy.

"I collect cookbooks—old cookbooks—and I look through my old cookbook collection," Harris says. "I go to my kitchen and then I earmark old family recipes. I love beautiful photos in cookbooks, and I'll just look at things that I might want to make at some point." The screen-free ritual passes the time without turning sleep into another task. "I'm not sitting there saying, 'I gotta get sleepy,'" she says.

Throughout her 20-plus years of practice, Harris has also seen patients take up art projects and knit what she affectionately calls "insomnia scarves."

The key is that you shouldn't make your middle-of-the-night activity feel like punishment. Harris recalls a colleague who used to tell patients to go sit in their "insomnia chair"—and now those patients "dread that chair because they associate it with wakefulness." It's better to do something you'd genuinely choose, and to see it as a pleasant way to pass the time, not proof that the entire night has gone off the rails.

A few ground rules can help the technique work better:

Don't give insomnia a job

If you turn 3 a.m. into bonus productivity time, your brain might decide it's worth continuing to wake you up around that time.

“Don’t do your work. Don’t do taxes. Don’t do bills,” Harris says. “The more you wake up and do work, the more you’re teaching your body to have those awakenings.”

Skip screens when you can

Phones and laptops can pull you into texts, work emails, and other messages—and make it difficult to put the device back down. Some research also suggests that blue-enriched screen light may interfere with sleep. If a screen is your only realistic alternative to lying in bed with a racing mind, watch an episode of something you enjoy. Just treat it as a backup plan rather than your first choice.

Switch on a lamp

You don’t need to keep the room dark in an effort to coax yourself back to sleep, Harris says. Turn on a lamp and use enough light to comfortably do whatever activity you’ve chosen.

Don't fall asleep on the couch

Do it often enough, and you'll train yourself to sleep there and dread your own bed. When sleepiness hits, get up and walk back to your bedroom.

Plan for your excuses now

Don’t wait until the middle of the night to figure out where you’ll go or what you’ll do. “You have to think about all the excuses you’re going to come up with at night,” Harris says. “Think about it during the day, and problem-solve for those.”

If the rest of your home is cold, for instance, “keep a robe and slippers right next to your bed,” she says, and consider leaving an electric blanket in the room where you plan to go. Choose your activity in advance, too, and have your book, magazine, cookbook, or art supplies ready.

You can also adapt the technique to your circumstances. If you live in a studio or don’t want to disturb your partner, sit up in bed or move to a nearby chair. Harris also recommends remaining seated in bed if you take medication that makes you groggy or you have an increased risk of falling.

Once you feel sleepy again—and perhaps notice yourself yawning—return to bed. “See what happens,” Harris says. If your mind starts racing or you become frustrated again, “get back out, rinse, and repeat.” You might need to do that multiple times in one night.

If you’ve been practicing stimulus control for two or three weeks, while maintaining a consistent bedtime and wake time, and your sleep hasn’t improved, Harris recommends seeing a sleep specialist. They can screen for conditions like sleep apnea and determine whether you might benefit from a fuller course of cognitive behavioral therapy for insomnia.

And the next time you’re lying awake at 2 a.m., furious that sleep hasn’t arrived, remember: The wakefulness isn’t necessarily the biggest problem. Your reaction to it might be. "Change the narrative," Harris says. "Trying to force it is only going to make it worse."

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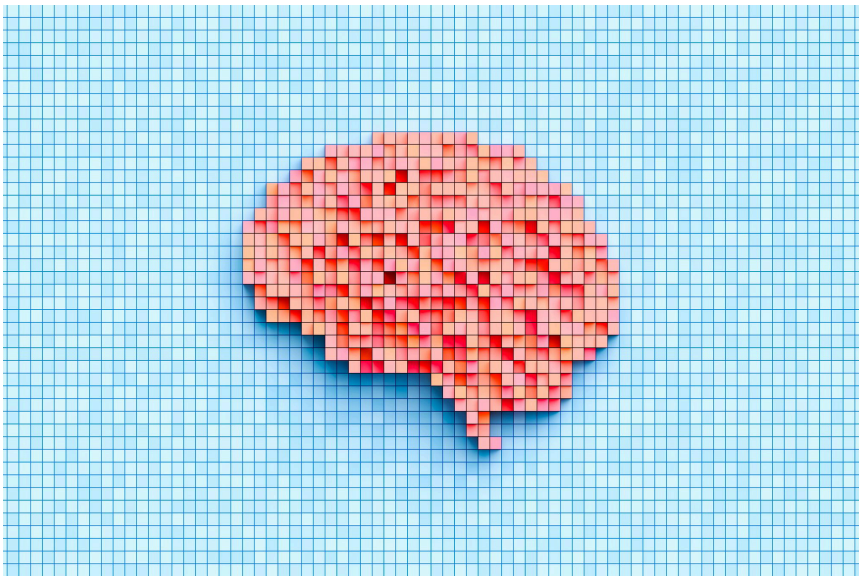
https://time.com/article/2026/07/28/what-to-do-when-you-cant-sleep/

Health | Mental Health/Psychology

Personality Is Linked to Genes, New Study Finds



Flavio Coelho—Getty Images

When it comes to personality, humanity contains all sorts, from people who thrive on socializing to those who'd prefer to have a quiet cup of tea at home. Psychologists have found that five dimensions of personality, often termed the "Big Five," are reliable descriptors of temperament. Given regular questionnaires about their lives and attitudes, people tend to score consistently across their lifetimes on extraversion, openness to experience, agreeableness (a tendency to go with the flow), neuroticism (a tendency toward anxiety and other negative emotions), and conscientiousness (like self-discipline and rule-following).

Exactly how these tendencies arise, and the extent to which they are the result of nature or nurture, are areas of active research. Now, in a paper published in *Nature* on September 2, scientists who examined the genes of more than a million people who also took personality questionnaires have revealed a swath of genetic variants linked to each of the Big Five traits. This information

opens the door to research into the intersection of personality and biology, helping to answer questions about how we become who we are.

What's the relationship between genes and your personality?

Psychologists have long suspected that some aspects of personality must be genetic, says Denis Bratko, a psychologist at the University of Zagreb in Croatia who has studied this question but was not involved in the new research. Previous efforts to look for these links, however, did not uncover clear correlations—no particular gene or genes for extraversion, for example—likely because study sizes were small and because there are now thought to be many genetic variants, each with a subtle effect, involved in personality. "Several decades of studies have seen failures because they [have been] looking for one or a few genes which will have a huge effect," he says.

To overcome these problems, the authors of the new study reached out to scientists around the world who manage repositories of data that include both genomic information and information about personality.

"We think that personality is super-important for health," says Michel Nivard, a professor of genomic epidemiology at University of Bristol in the U.K. and an author of the study. Scores on Big Five traits have long been associated with risk for mental-health diagnoses; neuroticism, in particular, is linked to anxiety. Personality can also help predict certain health outcomes, including whether people will stick with taking medication or seek out medical help for a problem.

What did researchers find?

The study revealed more than 1,000 genetic variants that appear to contribute to personality. Because the data came with all sorts of information about the people in the study—including, in some cases, the area where they lived, how much they walked a day, how other people rated them on personality questionnaires, and other measures—the researchers could see links between personality traits, genetic variants, and other parts of people's lives as well.

Looking at genetic profiles, the researchers could see that people whose variants were linked to extraversion were more likely to be infected with COVID early in the pandemic, says Nivard. "Which makes sense, right? Because when you loosen up rules around social interaction, then the people who will take advantage of those loosening rules the most are people who have been missing that interaction most," he says.

Personality was also linked to where people lived in midlife, the researchers found, using information from the UK Biobank that included home location. Those with genetic profiles linked to greater openness to new experience tended to end up in cosmopolitan cities, while those higher on neuroticism gravitated to affluent suburbs.

Overall, the study found that a relatively small but significant proportion of personality can be predicted by genetics—up to around 13%—reinforcing psychologists' impression that personality is a combination of genetics and environment. And it's not necessarily the case that personality is inherited: an extravert, for example, may not have extraverted children. The system is clearly quite a bit more complex than that.

Many, many genes—more than were identified in this study—are probably involved, influencing a variety of pathways in the brain, Nivard says. "That must be the case, given how diffuse we find those genetic effects to be."

“It's a wonderful paper,” says Tena Vukasović Hlupić, a psychologist at the University of Zagreb who was not an author on the new study. “It's finally empirical evidence that there is not one gene for whatever personality trait.”

What’s next for genetics and personality research?

Understanding the genetic variants playing into each trait may help psychologists and neuroscientists further explore the basic neurobiology of personality. “There’s this endless debate on whether our body and our experiences shape our personality, or whether personality shapes our experience. I'm super excited to go and use these results to dig into those kinds of questions,” says Nivard.

This information also raises the possibility of using such variants as a way to screen for problems down the road, says Hlupić. The variants themselves are only a small part of what might give people a predisposition to a certain mental-health condition, for instance, but if they can be used as an indicator of risk, and early interventions can help, they might be useful tools beyond basic research.

If you’d like to find out more about your own personality, the best way is still an academically validated Big Five test, Nivard says—not a genomic test. “There is no better way to know about your personality than to take a personality test,” says Nivard. “They're really good. They're not perfect, but they're way better than anything we could ever do with genetics.”

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https://time.com/article/2026/09/02/personality-is-linked-to-genes-study/

Ideas

- **The Danger of Ignoring Nepal**
  The climate disasters in Nepal are the essence of climate injustice.
- **The Missing Pieces We Carry After 9/11**
  Twenty-five years after Sept. 11, Tom Roston writes about incomplete mourning, the Windows on the World staff, and what it means to grieve and grow.

Ideas | World

The Danger of Ignoring Nepal

Sumnima Udas is a member of Parliament in Nepal and chair of the Parliamentary Committee on International Relations and Tourism.

Families in Nepal search for missing relatives at the National Trauma Centre in Kathmandu, Nepal, on September 1, 2026, one week after floods struck areas near the Nepal-China border. More than a 1,000 people are dead and around 4,000 are missing.Safal Prakash Shrestha-NurPhoto-Getty Images

Sumnima Udas is a member of Parliament in Nepal and chair of the Parliamentary Committee on International Relations and Tourism.

We are still burying or cremating our dead. We are still searching for our missing people. We are still gasping at the emptiness where our homes stood.

And we know something: the furious deluge that came crashing down from a mountain peak in northern Nepal, like a scene from an apocalyptic movie, and tore through the valleys of the Rasuwa and Nuwakot districts of our country was not a freak accident.

It was a warning from the Himalayas. Our majestic mountains and their glaciers are warming because of climate change caused by greenhouse gas emissions from industrialized nations that have

been burning fossil fuels since the Industrial Revolution. We, in Nepal, produce a mere 0.1% of global greenhouse gas emissions. And it is time for the industrialized nations to take responsibility for it.

On Monday, Nepal's National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority estimated that at least 1,050 people have died in the floods, 292 are injured and 3,916 are missing. More than 90,000 people have been affected. Around 600 of the missing people are foreign nationals from 39 countries.

The first reports, which pointed toward an earthquake setting off the glacial rage, were quickly reversed. What the seismometers registered was a warming glacier shearing off Langtang Lirung mountain peak and slamming into the valley floor with enough force to register a magnitude 5.2 shock, sending a wall of rock, ice, mud and water thundering down the Bhotekoshi-Trishuli River valley at a ferocious speed that gave communities along the riverbanks almost no warning.

Chinese monitors clocked just six to seven minutes between the collapse and the moment the surge hit Gyirong Port at the China-Nepal border. In Rasuwa district, officials recorded the Trishuli River rising as much as nine meters in 30 minutes.

Nepal is familiar with a pattern of extreme climate events induced by climate change. In July 2025, a smaller flood washed away the Friendship Bridge, which connected Rasuwagadhi in Nepal with Gyirong on the Chinese side of the border. In Aug. 2024, a glacial lake let go near Mount Everest, tearing through Thame village and destroying homes, a school and a health post overnight. These natural calamities are becoming more frequent and fiercer.

Nepalis are resilient. Every time a disaster hits, we mourn our dead, rebuild, and carry on. We call it karma, or fate, or the mountains doing what mountains do. But this isn't karma. The climate is

changing, and human activity is changing it. Our resilience becomes a quiet abandonment, a way for the rest of the world to admire how well we absorb losses it helped create.

A Himalayan warning

In Oct. 2023, UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres stood near Mount Everest and pleaded, “I am here today to cry out from the rooftop of the world: stop the madness…The glaciers are retreating, but we cannot. We must end the fossil fuel age.”

The Hindu Kush Himalaya is warming faster than the global average. Go up to the mountains and you can see it: bare grey rock where there was snow and ice just a decade ago. The region is often called the “Third Pole" because it holds the largest volume of ice outside the two poles. It is also one of the planet’s most important water towers, feeding ten major river systems and sustaining nearly two billion people downstream.

In March, the International Centre for Integrated Mountain Development (ICIMOD), an intergovernmental group working in the Himalayan region, confirmed what mountain people already feel: glaciers across the Hindu Kush Himalaya are now losing ice at roughly twice the rate they did before 2000, and have disappeared 65% faster between 2011 and 2020 than in the preceding decade. Nepal alone holds more than 2,000 glacial lakes.

An assessment by the Nepal government and ICIMOD identified 21 glacial lakes across the Koshi, Gandaki and Karnali basins of the country as potentially dangerous and capable of producing a damaging outburst. In 2016, the government of Nepal and UNDP worked together to lower water levels in Imja Tsho, one of the largest and most closely watched glacial lakes in the Everest region. The initiative successfully drained Imja Tsho to a safer level

and installed community-based early warning and response systems.

But new lakes keep forming, and old ones keep growing, faster than any single country can monitor them. Imja took years of international effort and millions of dollars to make it safe. Nepal has dozens of glacial lakes like it. We don’t have a fraction of the money required.

The arithmetic of climate injustice

And here is the arithmetic of the injustice: Nepal is one of the smallest contributors to global greenhouse gas emissions, yet its people, from remote villages to the Kathmandu Valley, keep paying the price for it. Nepal has grown its forest cover to nearly 46% of its land and draws around 90% of its electricity from clean hydropower. The climate disasters we face are the essence of climate injustice: those least responsible for the crisis are the first and worst affected, and too often the least equipped to recover.

Just as Nepal was turning a corner, under a reform-minded government promising good governance and attracting foreign investment, this disaster could set this part of the country back by about a decade. Our finance minister, Swarnim Wagle, estimates that rebuilding will cost between four and five billion dollars, close to a tenth of our entire economy, against a national budget of around $14 billion for the year.

Every major disaster forces the country to divert scarce resources away from education, healthcare, infrastructure and development and back into rebuilding what was lost. A country that spends its future paying for someone else’s emissions cannot develop. It can only tread water. Nepal doesn’t need another pledge recited at another international conference. We need the international community to move from symbolic gestures to real action.

We need climate finance that actually reaches Nepal. We need a Loss and Damage Fund that pays out when a village needs it, not years after the water has receded. Nepal also needs investment in early warning systems, continuous monitoring of glaciers and glacial lakes, and disaster preparedness that reaches the most remote mountain communities. Six minutes of warning is not a policy failure of Nepal's alone; it is what underinvestment in mountain monitoring buys.

And finally, the people who live in these mountains and the billions who depend on the water flowing from them deserve a voice in climate policy. Nepal should be central to that conversation. We are not debating what climate change might do. We are already living it.

Nature has a way of reminding us just how interconnected and interdependent we are. A glacier destabilized in one country can, within minutes, devastate villages, infrastructure, and livelihoods in another, while the bodies of the dead are found hundreds of kilometers downstream in another country. Nepal, China, and India share not only mountains and rivers, but also a common exposure to the accelerating risks of climate change. We need more regional cooperation, and Nepal, sitting at the head of these shared watersheds, must play a central role.

Nepal's mountains are our identity. They feed our rivers, our tourism, our sense of who we are. Now they are also ground zero for the climate emergency. The world needs to heed this warning: we need shared, urgent, and just action before more mountains give way.

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https://time.com/article/2026/09/02/climate-change-melting-glaciers-himalayas-floods-nepal-danger-/

Ideas | 9/11

The Missing Pieces We Carry After 9/11

Roston is an author of several books and a New York City high school teacher

Breakfast at Windows on the World in New York City in February, 2001.Angel Franco—The New York Times/Redux

Roston is an author of several books and a New York City high school teacher

Early dawn. A slice of last night's chocolate cake. Watching the rays of the sun spread over the city. Stealing a moment like this was a coveted morning ritual for some of the breakfast staff at Windows on the World, the restaurant that was on the 107th floor of the North Tower of the World Trade Center.

This was the meeting place where New Yorkers and out-of-towners went to celebrate birthdays and anniversaries; to revel with food and drink and to mark life milestones. And for many of the staff, it was a dream job.

"I would have worked there just for the insurance," says Windows sommelier and waiter Paulo Villela, who immigrated from Brazil in

order to get medical care for his son, who had a rare medical condition. “It was the best job.” He would tell his friends on staff, who hailed from dozens of countries—Bangladesh, Ivory Coast, Peru, China—“I’m never going to leave this place.”

On Sept. 11, 2001, so much changed. So much was lost. Most tragically, there are the 2,977 people who were killed, including 79 workers from Windows, and 91 of its guests. Those victims and their families are at the heart of this dark moment in history, which millions of us experienced from close or afar.

How one feels is at least partly determined by one’s proximity to the event. On that day, I was covering the Toronto Film Festival as a journalist. As a native New Yorker, I felt like I’d left my post. I was watching an 8:30 a.m. screening of *Monsoon Wedding*, a movie directed by Mira Nair, the mother of then 9-year-old Zohran Mamdani, who is now New York City’s mayor.

It’s a tenuous connection I mention because that’s what happened on 9/11; the attack cast in stark relief the myriad connections that are otherwise invisible in this city. Suddenly, we found out that our daughter’s fifth-grade teacher’s cousin worked at Cantor Fitzgerald, or a neighbor’s brother was a fireman who worked at Engine 54. On that day, the connections were rippled with panic. And then, for too many, grief. That manifested with the missing posters that filled the city for weeks; desperate pleas that became heartbreaking tributes.

Those posters were an early act of collective mourning. The city was still an open wound. You could smell the smoke almost everywhere for weeks. The randomness of the event—we were flooded with stories of those who died and those who didn’t by happenstance—draped over the city like an uncomfortable, existential veil.

One story was that of Michael Lomonaco, the chef at Windows on the World. He was in the basement of the World Trade Center, having decided at the last second to get his glasses fixed before he took the elevator to work. He felt the ground shake, saw debris raining from the sky, watched United Airlines Flight 175 crash into the South Tower, and observed people stranded above the 91st floor waving large sheets that were probably tablecloths from his restaurant.

“The memories are so vivid,” says Lomonaco, who helped start a fund for the families of his staff and who has gone on to run several successful restaurants in the city. “A generation has grown up since then, but it still seems like yesterday to me.”

A 25th anniversary marks a swath of time that can be illuminating because, to someone who is younger than 30, it feels like an eternity. Or a lifetime, which to someone who actually is 25, it is. But to someone who is over 50, as I am, it feels like a chapter. A long one, perhaps. But, still, a part of something else.

9/11 is a hinge of time that separates generations. It shouldn’t be surprising—but it always is—when I ask young folks about 9/11, and they just can’t get their hearts around it. It’s something that they learned about in class or saw on YouTube. They don’t feel it like I do. Like we do.

Those of us who are moved by this anniversary—no matter how close we were to the actual tragedy—should find some way to talk about it. “We have an obligation,” Lomonaco says. “When we talk about the people who died, we’re acknowledging the significance of their lives.”

But there’s a delicate balance. Many of us want to avoid the sadness: say “Never forget,” and move on.

Over 25 years, Lomonaco says he's gone through the five stages of grief—denial, anger, bargaining, depression, and acceptance—and I would contend he has wisdom to share. "When we mourn with someone else, we're actually mourning our own loss at the same time," he says. "That creates a human bond." He emphasizes the connections between us, which were so palpable in the days after 9/11, when lines of New Yorkers wanting to donate blood wrapped around the block.

For me, the interminable years that it took to clear Ground Zero and eventually build the new World Trade Center felt like a void. I won't overstate it. It did not consume me. But it was there. And, at least partly to fill that hole, I wrote a book, in 2019, *The Most Spectacular Restaurant in the World: The Twin Towers, Windows on the World, and the Rebirth of New York.* It has been turned into a documentary created with TIME Studios, *Top of the World,* which CNN is airing on Sept. 7.

I wanted to tell the life of the restaurant and the people who went there and who worked there. It was a way of honoring the people and a part of New York City that was erased. And, as Lomonaco indicates, it was also my way of working through my own personal grief: I lost my father when I was 10 years old, in 1980, when he was killed in an automobile accident.

I recently read William Styron's book *Darkness Visible: A Memoir of Madness,* which introduced me to the concept of "incomplete mourning," which is pretty much what it sounds like. I can see myself wrestling with incompleteness in the way that my books—one is about the bygone video-store era, and another is about how author Kurt Vonnegut sought to reconcile his World War II experiences by writing his masterpiece, *Slaughterhouse Five*—share a theme of loss.

But is there even such a thing as complete mourning? I stumbled upon a 2023 eulogy by Park Avenue Synagogue's Rabbi Elliot

Cosgrove, in which he refers to *The Missing Piece* by children's author Shel Silverstein. In the book, a circle goes looking for a wedge of itself that is missing. It rolls around and has adventures. And when it finally finds its missing piece, it is delighted—at first. But when it is complete, the circle rolls too fast and it is no longer able to talk to the bugs and other passersby and have the experiences it enjoyed during its journey. So, the circle decides to release the piece, preferring to live without it.

Cosgrove was commemorating the passing of another rabbi, Harold Kushner, who first made the connection between grief and *The Missing Piece*. In Kushner's words, "We're more complete if we're incomplete." I think that's a beautiful way to approach grief.

We need to see the light in the darkness. "In the face of loss, we must see the preciousness of life," Cosgrove says. Lomonaco agrees: "My appreciation of individual lives, of life, has grown," he says.

It's a bit of a trick to both grieve and grow, like keeping two contradictory thoughts in your head, except in your heart. I hope to be getting better at it. I'd contend that the city has managed pretty well with the 9/11 Memorial and its reflecting pools. They're solemn and reverential and, at the same time, thriving with tourists. (A New Yorker's sense of irony, and humor, helps with the grieving.)

And the Tribute in Light, those awesome spotlights that pierce the sky each Sept. 11, are a pitch-perfect way to memorialize the day.

"It's like going into a church and lighting a candle," Lomonaco says. "It's an act of mourning. But a light also literally lights our path forward."

Roston is an author of several books and a New York City high school teacher

https://time.com/article/2026/09/03/the-missing-pieces-we-carry-after-9-11/

Politics

- **How Democrats Are Pushing for a Supreme Court Overhaul**
  A Republican-led attempt to permanently limit the Supreme Court to nine Justices fell at the first hurdle.
- **Trump Signs Order to Rename Lake Ontario as 'Lake America' Amid Calls for Canadians to Boycott U.S. Travel**
  The move is the latest in a series of tit-for-tat measures amid an all-out trade war between the U.S. and Canada.

Politics | Supreme Court

How Democrats Are Pushing for a Supreme Court Overhaul

Supreme Court Chief Justice John Roberts, Associate Justice Elena Kagan, Associate Justice Brett Kavanaugh, and Associate Justice Amy Coney Barrett attend the State of the Union address at the U.S. Capitol on Feb. 24, 2026.Win McNamee—Getty Images

The House of Representatives on Wednesday struck down a Republican-led attempt to permanently limit the Supreme Court to nine Justices, with lawmakers voting largely along party lines.

The attempt to preserve the makeup of the country's top court was already a long shot: GOP Rep. Andy Biggs of Arizona's proposal was a constitutional amendment that required two-thirds of the chamber to approve. Even if the proposal had passed the chamber, it faced similarly long odds in the Senate and would have then needed to be ratified by 38 of the 50 U.S. states. But the attempt fell at the first hurdle in the House, with a 212-206 vote.

Still, the effort has put the Supreme Court—which Democrats have recently targeted over the conservative leanings of its decisions—firmly in the spotlight ahead of the November midterms. The

Supreme Court may have bucked President Donald Trump's agenda in tariffs and birthright citizenship, but it equally handed him victories in federal elections, his attempts to remake the capital, and his Administration's enforcement of a robust anti-immigration agenda.

The GOP has argued against "packing" the court, whose current 6-3 conservative set-up often benefits Trump and his allies.

But Democrats claim the conservative-led court's latest rulings show it's pandering to politics instead of law. Rep. Jamie Raskin of Maryland dismissed the proposal to cap the number of Supreme Court judges as "another partisan power grab by MAGA, our colleagues who fear for the results in the November election."

Democrats' criticisms coincide with signs of negative public opinion about the Supreme Court, with a July 2026 Washington *Post*-Ipsos poll showing that 46% of Americans believe the court is ruling on Trump's policies based on ideology rather than the law.

The conservative Justices have denied that the court's decisions are politically motivated.

"I think, at a very basic level, people think we're making policy decisions, we're saying we think this is how things should be, as opposed to what the law provides," said Chief Justice John Roberts at an event in May. "I think they view us as purely political actors, which I don't think is an accurate understanding of what we do."

The past few months have nonetheless seen Democratic lawmakers proposing other ways to revamp the court in an attempt to weed out partisan politics and rein in judicial powers. Here are some of those efforts:

Ongoing discussions over court size

The U.S. Constitution does not state how many Justices make up the Supreme Court, and the number of seats has changed over time, from as few as five Justices to as many as 10. Since 1869, however, the court has had nine authorized seats for Justices.

In 1937, President Franklin D. Roosevelt tried to expand the court by up to six Justices after the incumbents struck down parts of his New Deal agenda, but lawmakers decisively thwarted this.

Since 2021, some Democrats have attempted to increase the number of Justices. In April that year, four Democrats introduced a bill envisioning a 13-Justice Supreme Court, claiming it "would restore balance to the nation's highest court after four years of norm-breaking actions by Republicans." Former Vice President Kamala Harris, who lost to Trump in the 2024 presidential election, also said that Democrats should have a "real conversation" about changing institutions, including "expanding" the court.

As recently as May, Rep. Al Green of Texas filed a bill to increase the number of Justices to 13.

"I think that we are in a position now that calls for some significant actions taken by the Congress, and we ought to expand—and 13 is a pretty good number," Rep. James Clyburn of South Carolina said in an interview with NBC News last month. "A baker's dozen would be a good number to have on the court. And I would hope we would get people on the court who will follow the constitutional underpinnings of this great nation of ours."

Proposed term limits

In July, Sen. Sheldon Whitehouse of Rhode Island and his fellow Democrats in the upper chamber proposed to limit new Justices' active terms to 18 years.

Per Whitehouse's bill, the next President would nominate two new Supreme Court Justices in the first and third years after a presidential election.

The bill also states that only the nine most recently appointed Justices on the bench would rule on cases under the Court's appellate jurisdiction. A Justice will spend about 18 years participating in those cases, after which the Justice would be limited to hearing original jurisdiction cases and performing other duties.

"Term limits and regular appointments would make the Court more representative of everyday Americans and help restore the Supreme Court to the proper independent body it was created to be," Whitehouse said.

Multiple polls, dating back to at least 2014, show broad public support for Justices' term limits.

Other ethics concerns

Beyond debates over judicial tenures, some Supreme Court Justices have been hounded by ethics controversies.

Clarence Thomas and Samuel Alito have faced allegations of conflicts of interest and questions over financial disclosures, including accepting undisclosed luxury trips and other gifts—claims they have disputed.

Democrats have since introduced a handful of bills in hopes of restoring confidence in the judiciary. One bill sought to ban federal judges from receiving gifts valued over $50 in an instance or $100 in total per year per source save for specific exceptions, and a bill also seeks to require Justices and other members of the judiciary—as well as their spouses and children—to put certain assets in blind trusts.

The Supreme Court has also been accused of “abusing” what is called the “shadow docket”—the docket which the Trump Administration has resorted to in seeking emergency relief in cases challenging the President’s agenda. The Trump Administration has applied for dozens of emergency appeals before the Supreme Court, and the court has, in most cases, ruled in the Administration’s favor. Rep. Raskin has introduced a bill that would require the Supreme Court to issue public legal justification for certain orders issued from this docket.

Sen. Chris Murphy of Connecticut introduced a bill in July mandating an ethical code of conduct for the Supreme Court, appointing an Ethics Investigations Counsel, and requiring Justices to publicly disclose why they decided to recuse themselves from a case. The bill aims to strengthen enforcement of the court’s previous ethics code.

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https://time.com/article/2026/09/03/how-democrats-are-pushing-for-a-supreme-court-overhaul/

Politics | Canada

Trump Signs Order to Rename Lake Ontario as 'Lake America' Amid Calls for Canadians to Boycott U.S. Travel

President Donald Trump on Thursday signed an Executive Order instructing Interior Secretary Doug Burgum to rename Lake Ontario as “Lake America.”

The change is set to take effect immediately, he said. Trump earlier in the week had floated the idea of a new moniker for the lake, which borders the Canadian province of Ontario and the U.S. state of New York.

Trump signed a similar order upon returning to the White House last year, renaming the Gulf of Mexico as the "Gulf of America."

This most recent name change is the latest in a series of tit-for-tat measures amid an all-out trade war between the U.S. and Canada.

British Columbia’s Premier David Eby on Tuesday called for residents not to travel to America unless it's absolutely essential.

“I’m asking British Columbians: If you have a choice, please don’t travel to the United States. Choose another place to do your tourism,” Eby said at a press briefing. “If you can choose a Canadian product, instead of an American one, please choose it… by being our own best customer, we can help respond and support Canadians in every corner of this amazing country.”

While Eby is leading the charge on a travel boycott from the Canadian province, other lawmakers are further clamping down on a boycott of U.S. products.

“When you’re at war, you protect your own, you protect your own backyard,” said Ontario Premier Doug Ford on Wednesday. “You don’t go down to the U.S. and buy a product. There’s nothing that we can’t make here in Ontario, or across the country.”

Finance Minister François-Philippe Champagne expressed a similar sentiment, telling reporters: “The biggest power we have, each and every one of us, is our purchasing power. We can choose when we go to the grocery store or to the hardware store to buy Canadian.”

Has Canadian travel to the U.S. declined since Trump returned to office?

Prior to Eby’s tourism plea, Canadian travel to the U.S. had shown a jump in visitors after a widely-reported decline.

In May, the number of Canadians visiting the U.S. was up by 9.9% compared to the same month a year prior, according to Statistics Canada. In June, the number of Canadian-resident return trips from the United States increased 5.0% year over year. The number of Americans visiting Canada was also higher, with a 6.1% rise year over year.

However, in the first quarter of 2026, Canadian residents took 5.5 million trips that included an outbound visit to the United States, a year over year decline of 10.6%. Spending while visiting the U.S. by Canadians during this period was also down by 13.6%.

Figures for the start of 2026 fall in line with a trend that has seen Canadian travel to the U.S. decline since Trump returned to Office last year.

Cell phone data analysis published by the University of Toronto in May found a 42% year-over-year median decline in Canadian travel to U.S. metropolitan areas.

The research also found that “when Canadians travel to the U.S., they are visiting fewer locations and staying for less time than they used to.”

Some metro areas such as Myrtle Beach, South Carolina, and Panama City, Florida, saw drops in Canadian tourism of at least 60%. In Florida, the decline in visits has persisted with an average decrease of just under 14% across the state during the first six months of 2026.

How U.S.-Canada talks collapsed into an all-out trade war

Relations between the U.S. and Canada have deteriorated further since the collapse of high-stakes trade talks last week resulted in U.S. tariffs of 50% on various Canadian products going into effect on Aug. 22, with no CUSMA exception.

In response, Canada has imposed retaliatory tariffs of up to 50% on certain U.S. goods.

Trump has threatened to increase automobile tariffs on Canada to 50%, claiming: We don’t need Canada, they need us.”

The Trump Administration has also revived its rhetoric of referring to Canada as a “state”—a nod to Trump’s vocal ambition to annex Canada and make it the 51st state, an idea he has floated repeatedly since returning to the White House last year.

Vice President J.D. Vance during a speech in Brewer, Maine, on Monday said: “We have to remember, Canada is a state—sorry, Freudian slip.”

Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney, meanwhile, has drawn focus to Canada’s burgeoning trade relations with other countries.

“Over the last year alone, Canada has signed more than 20 trade and security deals across five continents,” he said Wednesday. “Canada is now the best connected economy in the world,” he claimed, pointing towards trade alliances with countries in South Asia and Europe.

Carney in January met with China’s President Xi Jinping to forge what he called a “new strategic partnership” to end Canada's economic reliance on the American market. While meeting with Canada’s second-largest export market, Carney agreed to cut his country’s 100% tariff on Chinese electric cars in return for lower tariffs on Canadian farm products, including canola seeds, a major Canadian export.

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https://time.com/article/2026/08/27/trump-lake-ontario-america-order-canadians-boycott-us-travel-trade-war/

Sports

- **Colin Kaepernick on Threats He Faced, His NFL Exile, and That Jay-Z Lyric**
  The former NFL quarterback tells his story in a new memoir

Sports | Football

Colin Kaepernick on Threats He Faced, His NFL Exile, and That Jay-Z Lyric

Following a string of high-profile police shootings of Black men 10 years ago, San Francisco 49ers quarterback Colin Kaepernick began protesting such incidents by sitting during the national anthem at preseason games. What began as a quiet action turned into a fevered national debate about freedom of expression, patriotism, and so much more.

In Kaepernick's new memoir, *The Perilous Fight*, the quarterback explains that his action was spontaneous. He wasn't even in uniform on August 13, 2016, the first time he sat during the anthem. "I hadn't given the anthem a second's thought before I walked out onto the field that day, but it hit me in that moment that I should find a seat," Kaepernick writes. "I didn't want to stand up while that song was playing. Rosa Parks had refused to give up her seat on the bus to a white person in 1955. Muhammad Ali wouldn't step forward when his name was called by the draft board for the Vietnam War in Louisville in 1967. Tommie Smith and John Carlos raised black-gloved fists in the air during the playing of the anthem at the 1968 Olympics. They didn't like what they saw, the way this nation touted its commitment to justice and at the same time showed little interest in it, and they took action. Those inspiring Americans had the courage of their convictions and literally changed the world in the process."

Kaepernick, despite leading the 49ers to the Super Bowl in 2013 and throwing 16 touchdown passes, against just four interceptions, for a bad 49ers team in 2016, hasn't played in the NFL since that season. In 2019, he and former teammate Eric Reid, who joined

Kaepernick in kneeling during the anthem, settled a collusion lawsuit against the NFL. In late August, a decade after he etched his name in history, Kaepernick sat down with TIME to talk about why he hasn't spoken up much about his protests, his relationship with the anthem today, his differences with Jay-Z, and the state of policing in the United States.

(This interview has been edited and condensed for length and clarity)

You've released a book, *The Perilous Fight*. Why tell your story now?

One, it's 10 years since the protest. I've gotten so many questions about why did I protest, what happened, what led up to it, the details behind the scenes of all of the moments. Not just the protest, but owners in the NFL, the conversations that were happening there, the workout in 2019 and all the things that transpired around that. Then also just the work that we're doing directly in the communities. It felt like it was a great time to be able to go out, answer some of those questions, and also be able to give insight into how we build, how we move forward together. I think it's especially critical in a moment like this.

The book starts with a harrowing incident of racial hostility involving the *N* word that you experienced as a child—one you weren't comfortable sharing with your parents, who adopted you and are white. Why start there?

One of the reasons we wanted to start with that moment of going through the neighborhood, being tied to a rose tree, and the dynamic of not feeling comfortable telling my parents is it really sets the stage for the rest of the book, and sets the stage for the rest of my life. I had to navigate the realities that you face when you are Black in predominantly white spaces. I had so many questions around, "You lived a privileged life. Everything was all good.

Middle-class white family. What are you upset about?” And from the outside looking in, I understand how it can look that way. But also the reality of the experience, and what I went through, is also something that's important to put in context.

You didn't really do any interviews during the heat of 2016 and 2017, and in the aftermath. What was your thinking on not doing these types of interviews then?

Yeah, it's interesting because I get both sides of that question. During the 2016 season, it was like, "Why are you talking so much? Be quiet.” As an NFL quarterback, you're required to speak three times a week. So reporters can ask you whatever they would like. I'm happy to answer any questions as part of that. But post that moment, one thing I realized was, it felt like there was a very, very intentional effort to make me the sole figure, or the sole voice, of the movement. I thought it was important to create space for other voices to be able to step up. And one of the reasons that I thought that approach was so important is looking back historically, yes, we need strong leaders, but we need strong people collectively. That's actually what allows us to be able to sustain over time. Also, as part of that, I thought it was very important as they were very intentional attacks to try to discredit me, discredit what I was capable of on the field, discredit my character. In those efforts of trying to discredit me, they were also trying to discredit the broader movement.

Colin Kaepernick kneels during the national anthem flanked by Eli Harold, left, and Eric Reid, right, before an NFL game against the Dallas Cowboys in Santa Clara, Calif. on Oct. 2, 2016.Marcio Jose Sanchez—AP

If there's one athlete who has stepped up in the way that you wanted, who would that be?

I think there are voices across the board that have stepped up. I would say my brother Eric Reid. I'm always going to bring him up. Love Eric. He continued the protest after I was blackballed. He himself went through the same reality. His final season, [he] went out, set two franchise records, was cut, and never saw the field again. We had voices throughout the NBA step up. Whether that was LeBron, we saw Steph Curry, we saw Carmelo, we saw KD, all stepping to the forefront. We saw this with Megan Rapinoe, doing that on an international stage. We're seeing it to this day throughout Europe. I would not have had the insight that this would have had the lasting impact internationally the way it does, and that's just within the sports realm. More broadly, what I think it's done is created opportunities, whether it is on a national stage, international stage, or within local communities. People saying, "Oh, this actually opened the door for me to be able to do the work in a way I previously wasn't able to."

In 2016, when you first started sitting, and then kneeling, during the national anthem, you're in this national spotlight and firestorm. Was there one surreal moment you experienced that we didn't see during this time?

One surreal moment early on, we had a high school, Castlemont in Oakland. After I took a knee, they went out the next week and took a knee, and I went to go visit them the following week at their game. I had a moment where I was in the locker room with them before the game. They're hyping each other up. It's going to be a big game for them. And one of the players says, "We don't get to eat at home. So we're going to go eat on this field."

That is too often a reality within communities. Not only navigating threats against their life, but navigating whether or not they're even going to have a meal. For me, that was such a surreal moment that athletes in high school and students in high school are going out, trying to chase their dreams and compete at the highest level. They are willing to stand up and risk themselves to go out and advocate for their community, while at the same time not knowing whether or not they're going to have a meal when they get home. That really encapsulated and painted a surreal picture of how dire this is. While the broader national conversation was happening, this is just the reality on the ground.

Were you physically or psychologically threatened while protesting?

Threats became so normalized that I didn't really think about them too much. You get attacked from the President of the United States. You're getting attacked from senators. You have people trying to send bombs to your home. Online threats and mail threats. My now wife Nessa, as I was getting these threats, was like, "You can't be staying at your house alone." She was in New York at the time. But that ultimately led to me staying at [manager Tony Ng's] house for

the rest of that 2016 season, just so people didn't know where I was at.

Were you ever scared?

No. I also think you get a little bit of the football mentality. If someone is going to try to do something, they're either going to try to do it or aren't. My responsibility is to be prepared for whatever that is.

Did you ever worry that what happened to you served as a warning to other athletes? That as a result of you not playing in the NFL anymore, they were quiet rather than speaking up?

Absolutely. I know the intention was to send that message: If you try to advocate for the Black community, if you try to fight against the status quo and create a different and better environment, we will take everything we can from you. And this actually showed up in one of our Know Your Rights camps in Las Vegas. One of our young high school students pulled me aside in the middle of the camp. "Hey, I really love football. I also really want to fight for my community and for that to be better. Which one do you think I should choose?"

The fact that they have made that a conversation, that people feel like they have to choose, that is the very thing that I have to continue to fight against. I don't think there is an either-or. We can be phenomenal at our profession. We also can advocate for our community and a better society, better conditions for our people.

In the last nine years of NFL exile, did deciding to stand for the anthem in order to get signed ever cross your mind?

No.

Why not?

Because I set out with a clear goal and clear objective, and the conditions in our society have not changed. There's been progress made in some areas, but holistically, when we look at the climate and environment that we are living in today, those conditions largely have not changed. There is never going to be a moment where I take a position of, “Hey, I'll stand up so I can get my career back.” Because that then becomes a moral concession: If you threaten my career, or if you threaten my money, I will actually say I don't care about the people, and I will look at this just from an individual perspective. That was a line I was not going to cross.

In the book, you detail conversations you had with a few teams around the league. Which team did you feel closest to signing with?

There were three teams that I thought were close. The first was the Seattle Seahawks. In 2017, flew up there, met with Pete Carroll, John Schneider, the head coach and GM of the Seahawks. When I got there, basically the conversation was, “We know you're a starting quarterback.” I didn't do a

workout while I was there. They're like, “We know you can play. We've game-planned for you the last few years. That's not a question for us.” The entire conversation while I was there was just around my politics, taking the knee, how I thought about policing, how I thought about the military, what their community would think, what potential players would think.

In retrospect, it was fascinating to me on a few different fronts. One, the NFL claims it’s a meritocracy. So walking in a building and telling me you know I'm a starter, and not walking out with an offer makes that fall flat on its face. The second part is I just think about it from a labor-laws perspective. Being the owner of a business, a company, I would never be able to ask those questions and get away with it.

They didn't sign me that year. Reached back out the following year to have me come in for a workout. Had booked the flight, was ready to go out there, and prior to getting on the flight, they called my agent. Said, "Well, before he comes out to work out, will he commit to not taking a knee?" I said no. I won't commit to that. Canceled the flight. Canceled the workout. Never heard from them again. [*A spokesperson for the Seahawks did not respond to TIME's request for comment.*]

The second one was the Ravens, and this one came about because we played against the Ravens in the Super Bowl. Jim Harbaugh was my coach during that time. His brother John Harbaugh was head coach of the Ravens, and I reached out to Jim and wanted to get his perspective. "Is there anyone that you know that would be interested? Do you think your brother would be open to a call?" John was on board and was like, "Yeah, let's do it." John went back, advocated for it, wanted to sign me. "It got shut down from above me. I don't have the power to just outright make that decision. But if it was my choice, you would be here." [*A Ravens representative referred TIME to a 2017 quote from Baltimore general manager Ozzie Newsome—now an executive vice president with the team—who said, "(Ravens owner) Steve Bisciotti has not told us we cannot sign Colin Kaepernick, nor has he blocked the move. Whoever is making those claims is wrong."*]

Then the third one was the Raiders in 2022. Had run into [Raiders owner] Mark Davis at an airport. This was actually the first time I had been face-to-face with one of the owners blackballing me. It was a very interesting conversation because it was almost disconnected from the reality of what was going on. Saw me and was like, "Hey, what's up? How are you doing? What you been up to?" I was like, "What? What are you talking about? I've been trying to play, and you've been keeping me out."

That led to a follow-up conversation about me trying to play. He came and sat in my living room, and we talked about playing for

the Raiders. That led to a workout with the Raiders and Josh McDaniels. Workout went great. Josh McDaniels, after the fact, was like, “He looked bigger, stronger, faster than last time saw you.” Mark Davis came in the room after. “So proud of you. That was great workout.” One of the scouts on the way back said, “I'm surprised they let you walk out of the building without signing you. That’s the best workout we've had in years from a quarterback.” Never heard from him again. [*The Raiders declined to comment.*]

When Jim, who coached Michigan to the 2023 national title, got the job with the Los Angeles Chargers in ‘24, did you reach out to him? Was there any conversation there?

Yeah.

What happened?

He told me that was a table he was not willing to stand on. It was disappointing because prior to that he had been advocating for me. Said I should be a starter. I can help a team win championships. Had a conversation with him and said, "Look, I don't even care what the role is. Like I know Justin Herbert's there. I know the reality of what you have to navigate as a head coach. Let me take the No. 2 spot then. Let me come in, just show you, show everyone else what I can do.” Wouldn't do it. No opportunity, no workout.

Has that affected your relationship with him?

Yeah. And I'll say, also in part because there was a conversation that was put out that he had offered me a coaching job, which just wasn't true. I don't know where and why that came out. That's made the relationship a little bit different since. [*When asked to respond to Kaepernick’s comments to TIME about joining the Chargers as a player or coach, Harbaugh, through a Chargers spokesperson, pointed to a 2024 press conference, in which he said he “pulsed” Kaepernick’s interest in coaching.*]

Why are you confident that you are ready to be an NFL quarterback right

now?

Because I train for it. I rely on my training and preparation for any moment. I've grown confident in my ability to continue to stay ready because I've shown that the training works, and I've shown that I've been able to go out and perform.

What's your relationship with the national anthem today? When you go to sporting events, what do you do?

I don't go out for the *Star-Spangled Banner*. I'm either seated where I'm at, or I'm not out there at all, and then show up when it's time for the actual game to come on.

Your daughter is 4. When this time is right, what will you say to her about the national anthem?

This is actually a funny and timely question. We just went through the process of moving. We're putting some of the artwork up and pictures up. We have the TIME cover framed. I don't like having any of my stuff in rooms that I'm in. Feels weird to me. But my wife wants to have stuff up. And my daughter found it, and she grabbed it and was like, "Oh, this is going to my room." But she was like, "Baba, why are you taking a knee like this?" She's showing me how I'm taking a knee. Not a conversation I was expecting to be having at 3 ½ years old.

What did you say to her about it?

“Well, Baba was protesting to try to create a better life for everyone. Thought all people should be able to be successful and have good lives and be treated fairly.”

What are you going to tell her when she asks about why you stopped playing in the NFL?

It's going to be an honest conversation, in part because I also know I have to prepare her for the reality that she's going to walk into rooms and they're going to see her last name is Kaepernick. She's going to get asked questions and she's going to have to have to navigate things that she never asked for. Part of my responsibility as a father is making sure that she's prepared and equipped for that.

Going back to your early life a bit – you credit your parents with raising you and having your back. But there were many moments where they weren't as sensitive to your racial experience and awakenings as you would have liked. You make that very clear in the book and don't spare your feelings about it. Have your mom and dad read the book?

They have not read it yet.

How do you anticipate they'll react to it?

There's moments that they just don't know about. It is also something that, for me, in thinking about a white couple born and raised in Wisconsin, adopting a young Black boy, it is very difficult for them to understand the reality of what that's going to be for me growing up. As far as raising me on strong fundamentals and morals, teaching me to work hard, teaching me to treat people well regardless of what their position or status may be in life, all of those things they did extremely well. But when it comes to understanding being Black, being a Black man, what that means, navigating society, that part largely didn't exist. That's where a lot of the conflicts come in around culture, around perception, around

who I actually was. I knew they always loved me as their son. I don't know if they always loved my Blackness. And I think that's an interesting nuance to be able to navigate.

How would you characterize your relationship with them now?

I think we're in a good place. My daughter loves calling them during dinner. That is part of her routine now. They come out, they visit. But there is still some of the complexities there.

At several points in the book, you talk about the business of the NFL in the same breath as slavery. Of being photographed in compression shorts at the draft combine, you write, "My mind immediately went to the scenes I had witnessed in numerous movies depicting slave auction blocks." You also write, "I fully believe what happened to me was a form of buck breaking. That's a slave term to describe how masters used to whip and sexually abuse enslaved men in front of a crowd to dehumanize them and warn other slaves that they better not step out of line. I was made into a warning to other NFL players and professional athletes: You better not challenge the league's authority." Were you ever worried that people might be offended by that?

No. I know people would take things in the context that they want to. But the parallels between the two are undeniable. Bill Rhoden wrote a whole book around it, *Forty Million Dollar Slaves.* This came up for Curt Flood when he was fighting for free agency for professional players. "Well, you're making $90,000 a year, Curt Flood. How can you compare this to slavery?" And I believe his quote around that was, "A well-paid slave is a slave nonetheless," or something to that effect. Which speaks more to the institutions and practices around how you are treating people and the process that they're going through, and the systems that they have to navigate, as opposed to just taking something in isolation.

Two news stories weren't addressed in the book. One is your decision to wear socks depicting police as cartoon pigs in 2016, before you took your public stance. That offended law enforcement personnel, and police unions in particular. Why don't you, or why do you, regret that specific decision?

When I wore those socks, we were seeing police killing Black people with impunity across the country. This is something that has systemically been in place. It came out of slave patrols, built into modern-day policing. Now, policing in the U.S. exists in a way that we don't see in other areas throughout the world, so to me, that was sending a message around the inhumane practices that police were practicing.

It seemed to have an effect where some people would never forgive you after that. But you knew that was a risk?

The same people who are offended, in a way that, “hey, we're never going to forgive you for that,” why are you so remorseful for police killing Black people? Why are you so accepting of that? A pair of socks is so offensive to you, but the killing of a human life you're OK with. So, if we're really going to have a conversation around it, let's actually put it in contrast to the conversations that we're having. I'm going to choose valuing human life in every instance.

The other story is the shelving of the ESPN documentary about you, directed by Spike Lee. About a year ago, ESPN said in a statement that “ESPN, Colin Kaepernick and Spike Lee have collectively decided to no longer proceed with this project as a result of certain creative differences.” What were those creative differences?

We had approved for the documentary to go out, and that was not something that fit within their timeline. So the documentary is finished. It's ready to go. We're looking for potential partners to be able to place it.

Why didn't ESPN want it?

It's a great question. I know they have shifting priorities, as we're seeing publicly right now. We also know they were, I believe, at that point in time in the midst of negotiating their deal with the NFL. So I can't say that those things are connected. But I believe they're all factors. [An ESPN spokesperson sent TIME a statement: "*Two years ago, the three parties involved in this project came to a mutual decision, based on creative differences, not to move forward. Creative differences are not uncommon when several entities collaborate on a project of this kind. Because multiple parties were involved, we are limited in what we can share publicly. This is not new as the decision not to move forward was agreed upon Monday, July 29th 2024. We are grateful for the work that went into it.*"]

In a recent interview, Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez seemed to agree with the sentiment that "Woke 1.0 was crazy." She was referring to the period, after the murder of George Floyd in 2020, where there were calls, for example, to defund the police. You wrote in a 2020 essay "in order to eradicate anti-Blackness, we must also abolish the police. The abolition of one without the other is impossible." What is your response to AOC's characterization and other political characterizations that sentiments like you expressed went too far?

I understand the political realities that politicians are navigating. I'm not naive to that. I also think the reality is, if we are trying to create better communities that allow us to thrive, our resources shouldn't be going towards policing. They should be going towards resources that allow the community to thrive. When you invest in communities, they get safer. People do better. Crime rates drop. I would not discredit the work that was done around the country during 2020, because that has laid the foundation for the movement that we're seeing now. We're seeing a different wave of politicians show up: "Am I providing direct benefit to the people that I'm

serving?” I think that is the most important priority to be able to keep in mind.

Do you still support abolishing policing?

Yes. I think that's the work that we should be doing. Reallocating those resources to directly benefit communities and give them the resources that they need to be able to thrive.

You write in the book about how, in 2016, you met with your San Francisco 49ers teammates to explain in more detail why you were protesting during the anthem. You write: "I told my teammates how law enforcement in this country has always been an enemy of Black people.” In 2026, do you still feel that law enforcement in this country is an enemy of Black people?

The institution has not changed. It still exists in the same form it did in 2016. We're still seeing the same issues come out of it. We're still seeing that fuel and funnel into the prison industrial complex. So until those systems are dismantled and those resources are allocated to benefit communities, the institutions are serving the purpose that they were laid out to do.

A Nike ad featuring Kaepernick on display on September 8, 2018 in New York City.Angela Weiss—AFP/Getty Images

How would you characterize how Donald Trump has treated you?

At least to my knowledge, that was the first time I had seen a President use their position and political power to target an individual citizen. And I think that laid the foundation and set the stage for a lot of what we are seeing now. And in many ways, I feel like that was an initial test to see how far things could go. I obviously do not agree with his political views or approach. I do not believe that the work he is doing is actually to benefit people other than himself.

The NFL has reported giving more than $450 million to grassroots organizations to benefit communities in need. Do you see that as a sincere response to your protest or a PR play?

I view that as a PR play. There was a player-owners meeting. Bob McNair, who was the owner of the Texans at the time, said, "You need to tell your compadres to stop that other business," meaning the protests. Bob Kraft was in that meeting and said, "We need to talk about the elephant in the room and ending the protests." And Terry Pegula, the owner of the Bills, just said explicitly, "We need a Black face to be at the forefront of this to help us stop this." If it was actually to try to create change and benefit Black communities, the NFL's response holistically from the start would have looked drastically different. I would have a job. Eric Reid would have a job. The other players that were targeted throughout that process wouldn't have had to navigate that.

A protester wearing Kaepernick's jersey joins others in taking a knee, led by former NFL wide receiver Terrell Owens in support of the former 49ers quarterback on June 11, 2020 in Inglewood, Calif.Frederic J. Brown—AFP/Getty Images

NFL commissioner Roger Goodell admitted, in 2020, that the league was wrong for not listening more closely to the message and meaning behind protests like yours. He encouraged a team to sign you. Do you forgive him?

No, because he's still taking those actions to this day. That they have not changed their practices. The NFL just went through navigating race-norming, where they were assessing that the baseline intelligence or cognitive abilities of Black players was lower than white players, so that they could deny them medical benefits after playing in the NFL. It’s important to put it into broader context. This isn't a practice that just exists in relation to me and the protest. [*The NFL declined to comment.*]

The book details your relationship with Jay-Z, whose company, Roc Nation, partnered with the NFL in 2019 to consult on Super Bowl halftime entertainment and other performances and initiatives. Jay-Z recently brought you up in a rap lyric at Yankee Stadium, saying, “Buddy took a check, I ain’t even mad at him, but along with that check you gotta sign a non-disparagement. I’m the one they can’t control.” How would you characterize how Jay-Z has communicated with you, and used you or brought you up?

The fact that seven years after him cutting a deal to undermine the protest, unprompted, [he] brings me up, sounds like a guilty conscience to me. I would also say, just to make very clear, the distinction here. One, I did not sign a non-disparagement. But the second part of this is these are very different situations. He's trying to create a false equivalency around being blackballed by the NFL and having to go through the grievance process, the legal process that's already laid out by the collective bargaining agreement between the NFL and the players' union–going through that process, and then reaching a settlement at the end of it, because that is your path towards reconciliation, is very different than cutting a deal with the NFL to create personal benefit and undermine the protests. Trying to conflate the two is very disingenuous. [*A representative for Roc Nation and Jay-Z did not respond to TIME's request for comment.*]

Are you surprised that DEI is under fire?

I'm not surprised it's being attacked by this Administration. What I am surprised by is the capitulation by corporations, by organizations to go along with it. What I've seen is when you show weakness, that you'll bow down to them, that you'll capitulate to them, they're going to try to take that further and further.

Did you make any mistakes over the past 10 years?

One that I think about a good amount is, I had intentionally taken an approach of I'm going to do my best to not call out or attack people who I disagree with. I did not want to create an environment or narrative that was centered around Black people fighting and distracting from the intention of the protest. Even with Jay-Z, I didn't go out and do interviews around that. I believe people will see the work, and my hope is in seeing the work, people will look at and say, "Oh, that's how it should be done." But I don't know if that created additional space for people to take the narrative in

places that shouldn't have gone. It's one of those things that I'm very mindful of as I move forward.

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Gloria Steinem Brought Women Together to Change the World

Meg Wolitzer is a novelist. She is the author of The Female Persuasion, The Interestings, and The Wife, among other books.
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In the beginning, there was the famous story about the young journalist Gloria Steinem, going undercover in 1963 as a Playboy Bunny, all décolletage and rabbit ears, in order to expose a culture of degradation and misogyny. The Bunny episode is certainly the Steinem anecdote most often cited, but it's such an early story that it's just a canary, really, hinting only a little at what would become a lifelong commitment to feminism.

Steinem, who died Sept. 2 in her home in New York City at the age of 92, was an icon of second-wave feminism. As one of the co-founders, in 1971, of both *Ms.* magazine and, along with many other feminists, the National Women's Political Caucus, Steinem advocated fiercely and vocally on behalf of women's rights. She was also involved in the fight for the passage of the Equal Rights Amendment.

But she didn't consider her life as an "active feminist" to have started until 1969, when in her mid-30s she attended an abortion speak-out in a church basement. Steinem was there as a reporter for *New York* magazine, but found herself struck by the stories the women told, and the truths that they were willing to reveal in front of other people. She had her own truth, which she came to share.

Photograph by Susan Wood—Getty Images

Some years ago, she personalized the story further, in the dedication of her 2015 book, *My Life on the Road*, which reads:

This book is dedicated to:

Dr. John Sharpe of London, who in 1957, a decade before physicians in England could legally perform an abortion for any reason other than the health of the woman, took the considerable risk of referring for an abortion a twenty-two-year-old American on her way to India.

Knowing only that she had broken an engagement at home to seek an unknown fate, he said, "You must promise me two things. First,

you will not tell anyone my name. Second, you will do what you want to do with your life."

Dear Dr. Sharpe, I believe you, who knew the law was unjust, would not mind if I say this so long after your death:

I've done the best I could with my life.

This book is for you.

What is it that makes these words so moving? There was always something real and approachable about Steinem, visible in this dedication as well as in the interviews she gave and the speeches she delivered. You felt you knew her, or you wished you did. You even imagined being her, just a little.

I definitely had feelings along those lines toward Steinem. As a teenager I watched my own mother, a writer who hadn't been encouraged by her parents to explore her talents fully or go to college, become truly affected by the women's movement, publishing her first novel in her mid-40s. We subscribed to *Ms.*, and I became part of a consciousness-raising group in school. Though the term "consciousness raising" can feel outdated, I still remember those conversations the other girls and I had. Someone would bring over a container of Lipton's onion dip and a bag of chips, and we would go around the room speaking about subjects that until then had been kept inside, connected with what we had thought of as privacy, but which in some instances was really shame.

Later on, I was excited to win the *Ms.* magazine college fiction contest; and still later the writer Mary Gordon invited me to attend Steinem's 50th birthday party with her. In addition to being overstimulated and thrilled at seeing Steinem, I am pretty sure I also saw Carol Burnett, Sally Ride, and Rosa Parks—if that tells

you anything about Steinem's reach. Beyond that, it was so heady that I can't tell you much of anything.

"In my old age—really old age, since I'm going to live past 100, I hope," Steinem once said in an interview with *New York* magazine, "I would love to have a diner." She envisioned it as having "blue gingham curtains" and being "by the side of the road," and she went on to explain: "Diners are the most democratic places. Everyone goes—truck drivers go, people from the neighborhood, people in their tuxes after parties go… And in the back room," she said, "we could have a little revolutionary meeting from time to time."

Steinem never actually had a diner, although you could make the case that she did have a sort of symbolic one, because her life's work involved bringing all kinds of people together to talk, often to touch on matters of radical societal change. She seemed to be everywhere, from the nightly news to a mention on *The Mary Tyler Moore Show*. The warmth and genuineness of her personality, as well as her convictions, breadth of knowledge and experience, and her talents both as a writer and speaker, helped make her a reliable figure over all the decades she spent working for women's equality. In 2013, Barack Obama presented her with a Presidential Medal of Freedom.

Gloria Steinem at the offices of Ms. Magazine circa 1974 in New York City.PL Gould—Getty Images

Gloria Steinem and actress Olympia Dukakis take part in the National Abortion and Reproductive Rights Action League's "March and Rally for Women's Rights" in New York City on Oct. 7, 1995.LM Otero

President Barack Obama awards Gloria Steinem the Presidential Medal of Freedom during a ceremony at the White House in Washington, D.C. on Nov. 20, 2013.Pablo Martinez Monsivais—AP

The expression “the personal is political” easily comes to mind when thinking of Steinem, whose own origin story strongly shaped her inclination toward activism. Born on March 25, 1934 in Toledo, Ohio, Steinem lived with her mother Ruth after her parents’ divorce, becoming, at 10, the sole caretaker for her mother, who struggled with mental illness. Among Ruth's many other challenges was keeping a job. Feminism was in Steinem’s DNA (her father’s mother was involved with women’s suffrage and was the first woman elected to the Toledo Board of Education), but Steinem later realized that witnessing the contempt and disregard that people in power expressed toward her mother—seeing how she was treated as invisible—became a formative social justice experience for her.

She took her percolating consciousness off to Smith College, the all-women’s school in Northampton, Mass., where she studied government. But Smith in the 1950s, while academically rigorous, was also sometimes described by its critics as a place where

students went to get their "MRS" degrees. This, Steinem knew, was not something she wanted for herself. As she once told *People* magazine, “In the 1950s, once you married you became what your husband was, so it seemed like the last choice you’d ever have.” She added, “I’d already been the very small parent of a very big child, my mother. I didn’t want to end up taking care of someone else.” (Steinem did eventually marry, but not until her 60s.)

Being responsible for her mother not only molded her convictions about what she didn’t want, but also seems to have allowed her to figure out, earlier than other people, what she did want. And one thing she apparently wanted was experience. Steinem got that, traveling to India on a fellowship; then, later, at *Ms*., and as a journalist, mentor, and speaker to audiences around the world. Along the way, the glamorous Steinem had a well-documented love life that sometimes involved relationships with powerful men. Her stylishness—the signature aviator glasses and great hair—combined with her intelligence and political engagement, challenged retrograde and insulting ideas about graceless, unappealing feminists.

Betty Friedan, Elinor Guggenheimer, Eleanor Holmes Norton and Gloria Steinem, at an early meeting of the National Women's Political Caucus in New York, July 19, 1971.Don Hogan Charles—The New York Times/Redux

An officer arrests Steinem during an anti-apartheid protest outside the South African Embassy in Washington, Dec. 19, 1984.AP

Steinem with her cat in her New York City apartment on March 18, 1970.AP

It would not be an overstatement to call Steinem the “face” of second-wave feminism, whether it was her preference or not to be known that way. Steinem believed that her personal formation as a feminist had been importantly shaped by Black women. “I thought that they invented the feminist movement,” she said in 2015. “I realize that things being what they are, the white, middle-class part

of the movement got reported more." Throughout her life, both personally and politically, she was sensitive to the needs of various groups whose interests had been sidelined.

Steinem seemed to capture the feminist imagination in profound ways across decades, often acting as a convener of women. She was known for the "talking circles" frequently held in her home. In 2009, I received an invitation to her house in New York City for a reception to celebrate the filmmaker Jane Campion. Various women in the arts had been invited, and Steinem went around and briefly described everyone's work, one by one. I suppose "networking" took place that night, but that seems too corporate a term for what I experienced, which was a series of good conversations with women I admired, in the home of someone who mattered to us all. She somehow had time for all of this—more time, even as the clock sped up the way it seems to do as you get older, before it inevitably slows down, then stops.

I had cause to think of Steinem again some years ago when talking to a friend, the novelist J. Courtney Sullivan, who in fact I met for the first time that night at Steinem's. Sullivan was a core member of the all-volunteer group Immigrant Families Together, which worked to reunite mothers and children who had been separated at the U.S.-Mexico border. In 2018 she sent out a mass email, looking for housing for immigrant women and their children. She told me she sent 50 emails, and at that point received only one response in which the person volunteered her own home. It was from Steinem, who told Sullivan, in effect: Any of those mothers and their children are welcome to stay in my house for as long as they need.

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https://time.com/article/2026/09/03/gloria-steinem-remembrance-meg-wolitzer/

U.S. | Tariffs

Trump Says Tariffs Saved the U.S. Auto Industry. The Data Tells a Different Story

U.S. President Donald Trump, alongside Ford Executive Chairman Bill Ford and Ford CEO Jim Farley, tours Ford Motor Company's River Rouge complex in Dearborn, Michigan, on Jan. 13, 2026.Mandel NGAN—AFP/Getty

President Donald Trump said that he “revived” and “saved” America’s auto industry through tariffs. But industry data and experts on both sides of the U.S.-Canada border suggest a different version of events.

“I’ve revived, and indeed saved, the Automobile Business in our America,” Trump wrote Sunday on Truth Social. “That’s because of what I’ve done with TARIFFS.”

Manufacturers, however, have reported substantial tariff-related costs, and the auto industry’s production, sales, and employment have all declined since Trump returned to the White House.

Experts tell TIME that Trump’s escalating trade war with Canada could put further pressure on a $1.2 trillion industry, weakening its

global competitiveness.

Read More: *‘We Don’t Need Canada’: Trump Escalates Trade War With Threat of 50% Auto Tariffs*

Trump’s claim highlights a fundamental tension within his trade policy: Tariffs intended to protect American automakers increasingly target Canada, whose factories and suppliers have for decades been deeply integrated with the U.S.

Trump now plans to double existing tariffs, despite warnings that doing so could drive up production costs and undercut a vital American industry.

“The U.S. auto industry didn’t need saving in 2024. Americans bought roughly 16 million vehicles and the industry was profitable,” says Flavio Volpe, the president of the Automotive Parts Manufacturers’ Association, which is based in Canada. “Since then, tariffs and uncertainty have increased costs and disrupted investment, and 2027 now carries substantially more risk than it did before this trade war.”

Will the new auto tariffs on Canada help or hurt the U.S.?

When Trump introduced 25% tariffs on imported automobiles and parts in March 2025, the news immediately sent global markets roiling. But qualifying auto parts were exempt in accordance with the trilateral United States-Mexico-Canada Agreement (USMCA).

This month, he rescinded that exemption as part of a trade war with Ottawa, raising automobile and auto parts tariffs to 50%—a move that is expected to be consequential to both nations’ economies when it goes into effect Jan. 1, 2027.

“They feel entitled, and yet, we don’t need Canada, they need us!” the President said in a Truth Social post on Aug. 24, adding an oft-repeated accusation that “Canada has been ripping off the United States of America for years.”

Trump has argued that the trade dispute will hurt Canada while benefiting the U.S. But automotive experts say the two industries are too closely connected for either country to avoid consequences.

“If Trump goes ahead with a tariff on auto parts, the industry on both sides of the border would shut down,” says Volpe.

Canada is the largest export market for U.S. auto products, accounting for more than the next 10 markets combined, according to an analysis published last week by the Royal Bank of Canada (RBC). Auto trade between the two nations totaled $100 billion in 2026, making it a significant part of their nearly $900-billion-per-year trading relationship.

“President Trump can say the United States doesn’t need Canada, but 60 years of industrial integration says otherwise,” Volpe says. “In autos, neither country can seriously damage the other without imposing significant costs on itself.”

That integration is visible throughout the production process. Automotive parts often cross the border up to eight times before a vehicle is assembled, according to RBC.

Increased tariffs could incentivize Canadians to take a bigger share of their business to sellers abroad. The shift has already started.

In the decade before 2025, 49% of vehicles imported to Canada were manufactured in the U.S., according to RBC. But during the first 10 months of 2025, that number dropped to 36%, as a portion of Canadian vehicle purchases moved to South Korea and Mexico.

“If even higher tariffs come into effect, that trend may continue,” the RBC report said.

That would undercut what had long been a promising trajectory for the U.S. market, according to Sam Fiorani, vice president of Global Vehicle Forecasting at AutoForecast Solutions, LLC.

“The North American automotive industry has evolved over the last three decades into a globally competitive machine,” he says. “Without the resources that Canada and Mexico bring to the table, the U.S. has a tough time competing with the likes of the EU and definitely falls further behind China.”

But Trump reiterated his stance on Sunday, saying: “I don’t want Canadian cars, I don’t want Canadian parts, I don’t want Canadian anything.”

Canada has responded with reciprocal tariffs of up to 50%, which go into effect Sept. 8, 2026.

The countertariffs will raise costs for Canadian importers and could reduce demand for American exports—with key manufacturing states, like Michigan, taking the brunt of financial losses.

How has Trump’s presidency affected business in Detroit?

Michigan is expected to be one of the states hardest hit by the trade war, according to CBS News. It sits at the center of the U.S. auto industry, accounting for 18.1% of national vehicle production in the second quarter of 2026, and it is among the states most dependent on the integrated U.S.-Canada trading relationship.

Notably, Michigan is home to the “Detroit Three,” a moniker given to the trio of leading auto manufacturers in the country—Ford,

General Motors, and Stellantis—all of which have headquarters in or near Detroit.

Trump cited the Ford factory in Detroit as an example of how his influence has bolstered the auto industry. He suggested that the plant would have closed if he hadn't been elected in 2024 and said it was now flourishing under his Administration.

"When I announced that I was running in the 2024 Presidential Election, right at the beginning, Ford was getting ready to close their Big Factory, in Detroit," he wrote.

He said Ford decided to keep the plant open to "see what happened" after realizing that he was leading in the polls and claimed: "Now it's running 24/7, and it's one of the most profitable Car Plants in the World!"

Trump did not identify the factory, but his remarks appear to reference Ford's Dearborn Truck Plant, just outside of Detroit. There is no evidence that Ford was preparing to close the plant in 2022, when Trump announced his campaign, but it did announce in January that it was adding a third shift, expanding its operations to 24 hours a day, six days per week—one day short of Trump's assertion.

The President attended the announcement at the Dearborn plant, where reporters asked how renegotiating the USMCA would benefit Ford. "It's irrelevant to me," he replied.

"I don't even think about the USMCA," he continued. "I mean, you know, I want to see Canada and Mexico do well. But the problem is, we don't need their product. You know, we don't need cars made in Canada."

Trump declined to renew the USMCA in its current form on July 1.

Yet Ford—the company Trump held up as evidence his policies are working—is deeply tied to the North American market that he seems to downplay in his remarks. The company estimated that it would incur about $1 billion in tariff-related costs in 2026, according to *Business Insider*.

Its plants do consistently rank among the world's most profitable, as Trump suggested, but the company's broader results are more mixed. Ford reported a sales decline of 10% in the second quarter of 2026, which stayed on pace through July. It attributed the decline to "intentionally sunsetting select models."

Its sales could face further pressure as Canada moves to decrease its dependency on U.S. imports.

Canadians spend nearly $110 billion annually on cars, with 90% of those vehicles built abroad, according to RBC. And they are reliable Ford consumers: The Ford F-Series have been the best-selling vehicle in Canada for 15 consecutive years, RBC said.

"Canada buys roughly 40% of Michigan's exports," Volpe says. "[Michigan] also hosts 55 Canadian-owned automotive parts factories with almost 20,000 workers. The real risk is Washington damaging Detroit in an attempt to damage Canada."

Ford declined TIME's request for comment.

Trump's social media post also lauded the success of General Motors, another "Detroit Three" company. But like Ford, General Motors has reported a sales decline, decreasing 6.8% in the first half of 2026.

Fiorani believes that all of the area's automakers are certain to feel the strain of new tariffs.

"General Motors, Ford, and Stellantis rely on suppliers in Canada for U.S. vehicle production," he says. "Adding cost to those

vehicles will have the biggest impact in Michigan, Ohio, Indiana, and Illinois—where the bulk of the Detroit Three's plants are located."

Foreign manufacturers based in the U.S. could end up better insulated than domestic brands, since their plants are clustered in the South and they are less reliant on Canadian parts.

"Plants in the American South focus most of their suppliers in that region, providing a cushion for companies like Toyota, Hyundai, and Honda," he explains.

Like Ford, General Motors reported its strongest sales since before the pandemic in 2024—before Trump returned to the White House.

What is the outlook for the U.S. auto industry?

Apart from the trade dispute, the U.S. auto industry faces a difficult outlook. Sales growth is expected to plateau through 2030 due to "constrained consumer spending power and changing market preferences," according to PwC.

"Vehicle production in the United States has been sliding for the last two years largely because of the stagnating sales," Fiorani explains.

Affordability is a central concern. A June analysis by AlixPartners, a global consulting firm, predicted that new-vehicle sales will fall 2.5% in 2026. Inflation on everyday goods and the threat of increasing tariffs across other prominent sectors have left consumers with less money for major purchases and a more conservative approach to spending.

Cox Automotive also projected in January that used-vehicle retail sales and lease penetration would decline year over year, citing policy shifts, inflation, and a weak labor market.

And even before the Iran war brought on surging gas prices due to closure of the Strait of Hormuz, PwC reported in January that “fuel price volatility and changing regulatory landscapes have also introduced complexities” impacting the domestic demand for new or used automobiles in 2026.

These developments will also impact the auto industry workforce, Volpe says.
“Higher costs and political uncertainty affect investment, sourcing, vehicle prices—and ultimately consumer choices,” he says.
“Canada is the largest market for American-made vehicles, and it's not even a close second. Losing Canadian market share means losing sales and production for American companies and workers.”

The industry’s workforce is also contracting. U.S. automotive employment has been declining steadily at a pace of about 1% to 2% annually since 2001, according to the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, the decline has accelerated in 2025 and 2026, which show drops of 3% and projections upward of 2% year-over-year, respectively.

Even if production increases, Fiorani says that few new jobs will be created as U.S. automakers try to offset the increased costs of manufacturing.

Beyond North America, Trump's tariffs are hitting the global auto industry hard, as well.

The *Wall Street Journal* reported in July 2026 that it had absorbed over $35 billion in losses since the tariffs took effect—its most catastrophic dip since the pandemic.

Recovery is possible, however, according to Fiorani.

“Expectations for a soft recovery of 1.2% next year are dependent on the balancing of relations with Canada and Mexico,” he says. “If

that does not happen, the forecast will need to be lowered as consumers react to higher prices and reduced choice.”

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https://time.com/article/2026/08/31/is-trump-responsible-for-reviving-america-s-auto-industry-/

U.S. | celebrities

Tim Curry Dies at 80. Here Are the Movies and TV Shows That Made Him Unforgettable

British actor and singer Tim Curry performing live in Canada in 1979.Peter Noble—Redferns/Getty

Tim Curry, a multitalented star of the stage and screen, died Tuesday at his home at the age of 80. The three-time Tony Award-nominated icon was best known for his eccentric characters, his musical background, and his comedic chops, leading to a varied and successful career in cult classics and box office hits.

Curry “passed away peacefully at his home in Toluca Lake, Los Angeles,” according to a statement from his longtime manager Marcia Hurwitz. The cause of death has not been made public, but Curry had suffered from several health issues since having a severe stroke in 2012.

Though he was best-known for donning fishnets and a corset as Dr. Frank-N-Furter in 1975’s “Rocky Horror Picture Show,” Curry had left his mark with a wide-ranging career spanning albums, voice work, and more.

Here are a few of the roles that allow his unmistakable artistry to live on.

Tim Curry poses as Dr. Frank-N-Furter on a lobby card from the 1975 musical comedy "The Rocky Horror Picture Show," produced by 20th Century Fox.Movie Poster Image Art/Getty Images

The Rocky Horror Picture Show

Curry rose to cult status after taking on the role of Dr. Frank-N-Furter, the “sweet transvestite from Transsexual, Transylvania,” in the stage version of *The Rocky Horror Show* in London in 1973. His fan base crossed the Atlantic when he came to the United States to reprise the role in Los Angeles in 1974, before

transferring to Broadway, paving the way to the now-famous screen adaptation from 1975, *The Rocky Horror Picture Show*.

Reviews from New York were mixed—the TIME review said of the initial Broadway run that it was "not easy to see why this campy trash was a long-running hit in London and a smash success in Los Angeles." But by 1985, TIME's film reviewer recognized the movie as a "cross-generational phenomenon."

Chicago Sun-Times critic Roger Ebert said that Curry was "the best thing in the movie, maybe because he seems to be having the most fun."

Now, *Rocky Horror* is an interactive midnight movie phenomenon, with fans showing up to screenings nationwide in costume, shouting lines back at the screen, and singing along. The stage version was revived on Broadway in 2026.

Curry's breakout role in musical theater helped launch his music career in the 1970s and 1980s. He released three albums: *Read My Lips*, *Fearless*, and *Simplicity.*

Annie

In 1982, Curry starred in another stage adaptation—this time playing sleazy con artist Rooster Hannigan in the hit movie *Annie.*

Acting alongside legends like Carol Burnett and Bernadette Peters, Curry cemented himself as a scheming villain, the type of role he would continue to play in movies like *Home Alone 2*, *Muppet Treasure Island*, and *The Three Musketeers.*

In a 2020 interview with *Forbes*, Curry reminisced on the experience: "Rooster was a hustler, and people love that kind of character," he said. "He was a lot of fun."

Clue

In the 1985 board game adaptation *Clue*, Curry played the energetic butler Wadsworth, where he showcased his physical comedy. One of the most memorable moments comes at the film's end, when Wadsworth runs about the mansion, trying to summarize the night's events and explain the identity of the killer.

Since his death, tributes from his *Clue* co-stars have poured in.

"What an unbelievable joy to have shared a sound stage with him and to engage with such a master talent," Lesley Ann Warren, who played Miss Scarlet in the murder mystery movie, wrote. "I adored him."

It

In 1990, Curry took on a more straightforward villain in the miniseries adaptation of Stephen King's *It*. He starred as an ancient cosmic evil that took the form of a child-killing clown called Pennywise in the town of Derry, Maine.

His portrayal of Pennywise horrified a generation of children—without relying heavily on special effects or prosthetics. In a 1990 interview, Curry said he was trying to get in touch with the "human element" of the horror genre.

"We had a much more prosthetic version of this makeup, which was very scary-looking and beautifully executed but did too much work by itself," he said. "And I personally think that what is most horrifying is the moment of decision behind somebody's eyes when they decide to kill somebody—rather than a pint of blood and a pound-and-a-half of latex."

Tim Curry stands onstage for the curtain call at the Broadway premiere of "Spamalot" in New York on March 17, 2005.Stuart Ramson—AP

Other beloved roles

Beyond his most beloved roles, Curry had his fingerprints all over pop culture—in movies and television and on the stage.

His three Tony Award nominations came for his 1981 portrayal of Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart in the play *Amadeus*, his portrayal of King Arthur in the musical *Monty Python's Spamalot* which debuted on Broadway in 2005, and the lead role of troubled movie star Alan Swann in the musical *My Favorite Year* in 1992

On the screen, Curry was also beloved as the nosy concierge in 1992's *Home Alone 2*, where he is outsmarted by the film's young protagonist, as well as for his immersive work alongside a cast of Muppets as Long John Silver in 1996's *Muppet Treasure Island.* Both his penchant for camp and his undeniable vocal talent were highlighted in 1986's *The Worst Witch*, where he played the menacing Halloween harbinger, Grand Wizard Egbert Hellibore.

Curry's distinct theatrical voice also made him a top choice for voiceover work, where his prolific career spanned hundreds of animated series, audiobooks, and video games. After voicing

Captain Hook in *Peter Pan & the Pirates*, he won a Daytime Emmy Award in 1991.

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https://time.com/article/2026/08/26/tim-curry-movies-and-tv-shows-unforgettable/

U.S. | 9/11

How 9/11 Shaped My Life

The Tribute in Light is illuminated above lower Manhattan and One World Trade Center ahead of the 24th anniversary of the 9/11 attacks on Sept. 9, 2025.Gary Hershorn—Getty Images

Twenty-five years later, Sept. 11 remains a watershed moment, one with both personal and global implications. To mark the anniversary, TIME spoke to people with very different connections to the day, to hear about what they experienced at the time as well as the ripple effects. For some, the legacy of the date is one of profound loss. Others know about the tragedy mostly from history class. One thing is clear: The attacks that changed the world also changed lives.

Photograph by Andres Kudacki for TIME

A firefighter following in his father’s footsteps

An aspiring pilot inspired by legacy

A lawyer fighting for her client at Guantánamo Bay

A veteran finding new ways to serve

A pastor who learned a lesson about love

A volunteer who will cry with you

An Afghan immigrant still chasing his dream

A teacher who won’t let history be forgotten

A New Yorker committed to getting victims compensated

A Broadway director who found healing through art

A journalist who told the story of the attacks

A family formed on a day of tragedy

Colin McShane

Photograph by Andres Kudacki for TIME

I was 4½ when my dad died. I have only brief memories of that day. I remember my mom taking my twin brother and me out of preschool. I remember watching the TV at home and then going over to one of her friends', whose husband was also a firefighter, and watching it there. We were so young, we didn't really grasp what was actually going on. But as you get older, you start to realize what you've missed out on. It's not quite the same as being sad because you miss someone close to you. It's more like you're sad because you didn't really get to be close to them.

My dad was a cop for 12 years and a firefighter for only 18 months, but joining the FDNY was always his plan. For as long as I can remember, I also wanted to be a firefighter. I did the entry exam when I was 18, even though they don't take anyone until 21. I went

to college, but I think I was just killing time. I dropped out after two years, as the process ramped up. My mom kept encouraging me to consider other things, but she knew I had put all my eggs in that basket. I loved the routine and discipline of the academy, and I really tried to earn my spot; I didn't want to feel like I was getting special treatment.

A lot of things about the fire department don't change, and I remember thinking my dad might have stood right where I was standing, worrying about getting yelled at by some drill instructor for having a button undone. I don't have many shared memories with him, but that came close. He worked in Brooklyn, just on the other side of the tunnel from the World Trade Center. I wanted to go to a different firehouse, to let the guys make up their mind about me without having known his reputation, so I'm in the Bronx. The firefighters I meet that knew him, I feel like they're happy to see that I'm on the job.

On 9/11 I usually go to Mass at my firehouse and then drop by Ladder 101, where Dad worked. Last year for the first time I met someone who was actually riding that day, and he gave me the full rundown. They were staged at the mouth of the tunnel right under the towers, and as they sat there on the rigs, they watched the second plane come in. They could feel the impact and then they went straight in. From what I understand, his group went up a way, came back down, and were in the lobby when the building collapsed.

Dad was also a lifeguard at Overlook Beach in Long Island, and the lifeguards there put up a little memorial for him. My mom is not big on going to the firehouse or the ceremonies in the city on the anniversaries. I think it's just too overwhelming. So we do a more casual gathering in the afternoon. It's less somber, more a reason for everyone to just get together.

Sometimes the attention that comes with being a legacy firefighter is uncomfortable, but not for the reasons you might think. I don't have trouble talking about it; it was something that happened when I was young, but I had a happy childhood and a very fortunate life. I'm not looking for sympathy—I feel lucky to have had that role model of selflessness and self-sacrifice. On the other hand, I do miss having had a real relationship with my dad.

Do I wish he was still alive? Of course. I sometimes wonder if I'd be different if I'd known my dad. But that event shaped my way of thinking and shaped me. I'm very proud of what he did, and I think it's a very admirable and honorable way to die. And I wouldn't want someone else to have been in his place because I don't think that's what he would have wanted. *–As told to Belinda Luscombe*

Kelsey Griffin

Courtesy Photo

My journey of becoming a pilot started when I was 14, when I went to a youth summer camp sponsored by the Organization of Black Aerospace Professionals (OBAP). When I first told my parents that I wanted to be a pilot, of course they were a little bit concerned about the dangers that come with flight training at a young age, but they were also very supportive.

I took my first discovery flight with an instructor in 2022. At first I was definitely nervous, because there was so much going on in the plane at once. But once we were at around 2,000 feet, everything became incredibly peaceful. Looking down at the scenery gave me a sense of freedom that I never really experienced anywhere else. I knew at a young age that I never wanted to work a traditional nine-to-five job. I was also really big on traveling, and that discovery

flight showed me that being a pilot was something I could do every day and enjoy. I took my first solo fight in 2024.

Flight training is expensive, but my parents made sacrifices to support me financially as I sought out scholarships and opportunities. I was drawn to the LeRoy W. Homer Jr. Foundation Scholarship, because of their mission to empower future aviators. He was an African American pilot, and a first officer for United Airlines on Flight 93. I wasn't alive when 9/11 happened, so my understanding comes from learning about it through documentaries and conversations with my parents and grandparents and others.

The tragedies definitely impacted not only the lives of everyday people, but also caused major disruption in the aviation industry. When my mentor just started his career as a pilot, he got furloughed soon after 9/11 because the airline industry was completely devastated over Americans' fear of flying. I have a family member that is still afraid to fly on aircrafts.

Before I went to college, I became a private pilot and a licensed drone pilot. I briefly stopped my training after one of my friends passed away, but getting the scholarship lifted my spirits and gave me an extra push to continue my goal. The scholarship exists because of somebody who lived with courage, professionalism, and commitment to serving others. Knowing that I'm representing his legacy motivates me to work harder and fly with integrity, and never take opportunities for granted.

At Middle Georgia State University, I'm enrolled in aviation courses to finish out my remaining ratings and license and also to, as we call it in the industry, time build. I have to get at least 1,000 flight hours before I can go to a regional airline. It will probably take me about six more years of training to become a major airline pilot. African American women make up less than 1% of professional pilots in the U.S. I have had the privilege of connecting with several of them through organizations such as

Sisters of the Skies, OBAP, Aviation Career Enrichment, Pink STEM, and Youth in Aviation. Having this support gives me a sense of comfort and understanding that through hard work, I can also achieve it. *–As told to Philip Wang*

Alka Pradhan

via ICC

I was infamous as an undergraduate at Johns Hopkins for choosing classes in the afternoon so I could sleep all morning. My more diligent roommate would try to wake me so she'd have someone to talk to. On 9/11, I thought that's what she was doing. Maybe a minute or so after she got me to the TV, the second plane hit. It was terrifying.

Even at 19, I was on track to study the intersection of human-rights law and international humanitarian law. When it became clear in early October that we, the U.S., were going to strike Afghanistan in a way that seemed not entirely targeted and seemed to conflate the Taliban with al-Qaeda, that began my interest in all this. But to me, our actions didn't seem to comply with the law of war that I had been studying. I really did not anticipate that I would eventually use my specialization to litigate as hard as I possibly could against

my own government. But that is what I have done for the past 13ish years in my work at Guantánamo.

I was already working with Guantánamo detainees when, in 2015, I got a call from a friend at the Department of Defense, who said the military commissions, which are prosecuting those actually alleged to have organized the attacks on 9/11, were hiring civilians. He asked if I'd be interested in representing Ammar al-Baluchi, Khalid Sheikh Mohammed's nephew. I thought, well, there's nothing I can do that is deeper in the heart of this morass than the military commissions, because the CIA torture programs are at the heart of these cases. So I've been a defense attorney for Ammar al-Baluchi's 9/11 case since 2015. It has been in pretrial hearings for 14 years.

For 9/11, the actual fact allegations against al-Baluchi are that he transferred money to people who ended up being the hijackers. We have never contested the fact that he transferred money. He was in Dubai, he was asked to transfer money, he transferred money. The $10,000 question is: What did he know at the time? And the government has no evidence that is not derived from torture that indicates he had any knowledge of what was happening on Sept. 11.

The 9/11 case really is all day, every day. It is the biggest criminal case in U.S. history. I hold a top-secret security clearance, and I still don't have all the information I need about the torture at the black sites that impacted how Ammar is today and the statements he gave later. The trial has just been scheduled for June 2028, but I don't know if it will ever happen, and I think that is a very hard truth, particularly for the victims' family members. Witnesses have passed away, evidence has been destroyed by the government. The men themselves are deteriorating because the U.S. refuses to give them the medical care they need as undisputed torture victims. Millions and millions of dollars have been wasted on this exercise so far. It's the Jarndyce v Jarndyce of the United States.

However I also think this is one of the most important things I will ever do because it shows fellow Americans that this is what dissent looks like, and I know it sounds trite, but this is also what patriotism looks like. I am both grateful for and have great contempt for what the Department of Defense has done over these 25 years. On 9/11 I will reach out to the victims' family members who I am in touch with and convey my very deep sadness and anger over what happened. I will watch the commemorations. I will contemplate. Then I will start speaking again about everything that we are continuing to do wrong. *–As told to B.L.*

Jukay Hsu

Courtesy Jukay Hsu

I was student-body president at Stuyvesant High, three blocks from the World Trade Center. I had an early meeting that day with the principal about the plans for the year. So normally I'd be walking to school when the first plane hit. We evacuated, I think, just as the first tower fell, and I remember looking through these two-story plate-glass windows at this billowing black-gray kind of fog coming from one way as we went out the other way into a sunny sky.

I grew up in Queens. My mother was a social worker. I was lucky to get full financial aid to Harvard, and signed up for ROTC, then went to Iraq. I always thought service was public service. I was a second lieutenant leading a platoon of 40 men in Salahuddin province, kind of at the mid-end of the surge. Even with combat patrols, I ended up doing a lot around civil governance because counterinsurgency involves that. It was a very different kind of learning.

When I got out of the military, all my classmates were going into tech. I was like, If New York is going to become a tech sector, how can more people be included in that? All the soldiers I worked with never went to college. That's the difference between officer and soldier. Even though my platoon sergeant was 20 years older than me, I was in charge because I went to college. It really got you thinking: All these companies and jobs and wealth are being created, but two-thirds of Americans and two-thirds of New Yorkers don’t have a four-year college degree. In 2011, I ended up creating Pursuit. Our idea was to train working-class people in the skills tech companies tell us they need. The average student arrived making $16,000 and a year later has a job paying $94,000.

I left Pursuit to start a research organization called Bright Futures to focus on AI alignment for the benefit of humanity. There’s this idea that AI is going to be so dominant, so superpowerful, not just tools, but creating a being—we’re trying to create like a god, essentially, right? It's kind of crazy. So what does that mean for humans? This year I also joined the New York City Economic Development Board, which oversees and shapes AI policy.

Perhaps the future is not college versus noncollege. Perhaps it’s going to be AI and non-AI. But hopefully, there’s a way to democratize that and enable cooperation. We're creating these new digital minds, so you have to consider their power and impact. Early on in high school, it was imprinted on me that what’s most important is what happens to all of us. And the ability to have

agency in that. 9/11 helped cement that. Important critical junctures really can bring out the best in humanity, if we choose to respond.

Marc Rivera

Lev Radin—Pacific Press/ZUMA/Alamy

I was born in Puerto Rico but have lived all but the first three months of my life on the Lower East Side of Manhattan. Next year, it will be 50 years that I'm pastoring down here. Primitive Church is within eyeshot of the towers. On 9/11, I saw the towers fall and then didn’t set foot outside lower Manhattan until March the following year.

I had just dropped my younger son at high school a block away from the Trade Center and I was going into the church office when I saw my secretary outside. She simply says, “Look.” Sure enough, there was a gaping hole in the north tower. I could see what I thought was debris falling. Later on, I discovered it may have been people. I turned around to get my son, but the police wouldn’t let me through, so I went back to the church, and all of a sudden, a sea of people filled with soot and stuff came walking down our street. We opened the church to them. We had four landlines that were somehow still working. Eventually my son walked in with a bunch

of friends, all covered in soot. My older son also arrived from midtown. That was a rebirth moment for me. I was able to shift my attention to helping the helpers and healing the healers.

By day two after the collapse, I was doing what I've always done: galvanizing people and starting to help individuals, raising money to pay people's rent and medical bills and for funerals. We established the Ground Zero Clergy Task Force, which was simply clergy of different faiths, denominations, and traditions who gathered together to help at the site and to coordinate churches with FEMA and the New York City government. Every day, anywhere from 15 to 50 clergy would meet in the sanctuary, and then go down to the hole, to ground zero, to see what we could do. About a year afterward, I established a Northeast Clergy Group, which was broader and longer-standing. It tried to run the same program for people at the Pentagon and in Pennsylvania.

We closed those organizations eventually, but through them I saw the importance of not being so rigid or immovable in my theological training. Many religious people, regardless of faith tradition, tend to think that we have the patent on truth. This event broadened my perspective and really challenged me to make that change intellectually and also in my practice. When tragedy strikes, no one cares how much training you have, how many books you have written, how large your congregation is. Because the bottom line is love. I saw a fireman who looked so tired and I asked if I could pray for him. I didn’t ask what he believed first.

The most painful consequence for me personally was that my oldest son, Tim, was diagnosed with Stage IV colorectal cancer, one of the cancers that is covered by the 9/11 fund. He fought it courageously for three years, but this September will mark one year since his passing. He would have been 46. We believe he probably got it because we live down here.

One of my greatest concerns today is that there are still people in our congregation and in this community who may qualify for assistance through the 9/11 fund that the federal government set up, but some remain reluctant to apply. They're more afraid of the system than they are of getting sick. So, more than two decades later, part of our ministry is still helping people understand that the consequences of Sept. 11 did not end on Sept. 11. We are still caring for people. We are still encouraging people to seek the help that is available to them. And we are still learning what that terrible day taught us from the very beginning: when people are hurting, our first responsibility is to love them.

Connie Stevanus

Courtesy Photo

That day, I was working at a bank, and as I went from department to department, they were bringing this up on their computers. On my way home, it's just a two-lane country road, and there was so much traffic. Cars were passing me in either direction. They were state police cars. When I finally got home, I see my husband picking things out of the yard, and I didn't know what he was doing until I went to pull into our driveway. It was black, totally black, with small pieces of burnt debris. And it just hit me then what I was looking at. Flight 93 carried mail. We had mail in our trees, in our yard. The neighbor across the road from us had a piece of the United Airlines magazine in her yard.

We started volunteering at the Flight 93 National Memorial in Shanksville, Pa., after my husband had retired from work, like five years after 9/11. People come from all over—Europe, Australia, different countries. They like to tell you where they were and their experiences of that day. And then they always ask, "Where were you when this happened?" We get a lot of school students, and they're very alert to what happened here, so they're usually very quiet and very respectful. My 21-year-old grandson wasn't born yet. And when he was in eighth grade, I think it was, his school came out.

I never get tired of talking about it. Probably 99% of them still feel the pain and show their emotions easily when we're talking. Sometimes it's a little hard to be there, because I'm that person—I might not be able to say the right thing to you, but I can cry right alongside of you. At the Visitor Center, we have those three phone messages. You know that some of the passengers on Flight 93 had to leave messages because they didn't get an answer? Those are very powerful.

Can I share one little story with you? This was just after they were done with the excavation and the road opened up. So it was about two weeks later. My husband and I stopped there after work one evening. And it was just like the day of 9/11. Sunny, bright blue

sky, not a cloud in the sky. There was nobody around, just me and my husband. We looked down through the field, and you could just see where the crash site was, the fresh soil that covered that area. And we just stood there. And all you could hear were birds, the rustling of the high grass, and just silence. And there wasn't a flag. There was nothing where you would think something like this happened. You could see the little fence that they had around the debris field. But that is a moment that I'll never forget. *–As told to Karl Vick*

Shams Frough

Photograph by Kevin Serna for TIME

I was going into fifth grade when 9/11 happened. I remember, because it was two days after a famous Northern Alliance commander was assassinated. Obviously, there was no TV in Kabul, but our ears were wide open and we did hear about it on the radio. (From a very young age, I was listening to BBC Persian.) Then came the bombings, and life in Kabul became a bit hard, so for a short period, I went back to my village, Kapisa, which is 100 km from Kabul, where I had shepherding duties. I remember very well the big difference when we returned to school; girls were going too, and we no longer had to wear black turbans. Everybody wanted the Taliban to go, but we didn't know that eventually all these American soldiers would come and there would be a hot war again. We all thought the Northern Alliance would take over.

My mother died when I was young, and my father really worked to make sure his children did not have to work on the farm. I went to an elite Turkish-run high school; out of 6,000 applicants, only 100 were accepted—and some of those places were reserved for the children of government ministers. Most lessons were in English, but we also learned Turkish. I wanted to go to medical school, but I was young and male and I believed the hype, and in the last year of school I began working with the U.S. Army. I was sent to Kandahar as an interpreter. After I was nearly killed twice, I was transferred to the Department of Procurements in Kabul and ended up doing simultaneous translation for colonels and generals who were advising the Afghan military and police. I reported what looked like corruption in the Afghan procurement process, and then I knew I had to leave. It took three years, until 2014—a week or so after I resigned—for my Special Immigrant Visa to be processed.

My wife and I were initially assigned to Albuquerque, N.M., which was funny, because my Army friends always made fun of the mud huts in Afghanistan and there they were in America, only it was called adobe. When we moved to Chicago, I went to community college and so I took up driving taxis and Ubers. I'd study all week and then sleep in my taxi at the airport, because there was always a

three-hour wait for a fare. Then in 2021, I started a business called Kapisa Rugs; it was rebranded as Rugistan in 2024, and we directly source hand-knotted rugs from Afghanistan. It’s not easy with Amazon and other competition, so to keep prices down, I’m here seven days a week. Right now we have two locations, but this is not the goal.

I love rugs. I'll always cherish them. But hopefully, in about a year, it will be profitable enough, and my wife will have taken over and I will be able to fire myself. Some of my high school friends who didn’t join the Army are already doctors here, so I sometimes feel like I haven’t lived up to my capacity in the way I could have in Afghanistan. I am currently completing my master’s of public health at Southern Illinois University Carbondale, and I hope to start medical school in 2028. I joke with my wife that I’ll probably graduate alongside our sons. *–As told to B.L.*

Sari Beth Rosenberg

Courtesy Photo

My first day of student teaching was supposed to be 9/11. I was 26, in grad school, planning to observe a teacher teaching U.S. history at LaGuardia High School. My alarm-clock radio played *Z Morning Zoo*, a show known for its goofiness, but the hosts were talking about a plane crashing into the Twin Towers and I thought, “That’s not funny.” I turned on the TV, and that’s when I was like, “Oh my, no, this is actually real.” I got a phone call from one of my best friends who worked on Canal Street near the Twin Towers, and when I saw the first tower buckle, I yelled to her, “You have to run!”

The next semester, I was placed at Stuyvesant High School by what was once the Twin Towers. The air was constantly being tested in the cafeteria. And yet 9/11 never came up in the classroom. In the years that followed, I would have students interview a friend or family member about that day as a lesson in how history is remembered, showing them that they just collected primary sources.

Nowadays, students are more clued into current events on their devices and TikTok, so they're asking really interesting questions about 9/11, like "Why did we attack Afghanistan?" Many students don't understand the difference between why we went into Afghanistan in the early 2000s versus Iraq. Many adults don't know the difference if they don't really pay attention to the news or recent current events. How do you understand what's going on in Iran now if you don't understand the history of Iraq, Iran, the Middle East?

Kids don't talk about the fear of terrorists coming from the Middle East. The thing that kids are more scared of today is what they see as domestic terror coming from ICE agents. I've had to explain that ICE was created in 2003 as part of the new Department of Homeland Security, which was established in response to 9/11**,** and now it's being used to, in my opinion, terrorize communities.

I'm definitely going to bring up the 25th anniversary in class this year. They were born so long after 9/11, it's history to them. We need to find ways to cover more recent history. In a U.S. history class—or any history class—there's so much to cover, and we don't get to the recent history, from 1980 to the present, because it's not emphasized on tests and also you run out of time. *–As told to Olivia B. Waxman*

Allison Turkel

Courtesy Department of Justice

On Sept. 11, I was outside of Albuquerque, N.M. I worked for a not-for-profit then called the National Center for Prosecution of Child Abuse, and we were running a conference. And the receptionist where we were holding it said a plane just hit the World Trade Center, and you could go into our break room to watch it on TV. I went in just in time to see the second plane hit. Luckily I was able to reach my dad, who had a meeting downtown that day. I got him right before the phones went out in New York, and then we started driving back. We looked on our map. We tried to avoid missile silos because we thought that those might be under attack or shooting things. We had no idea. I drove crying. Not the whole time, but a lot. It’s a skill.

I lived in the D.C. area at the time, but I grew up in Manhattan, up in Washington Heights. I worked down in the Manhattan district attorney's office, which was actually in the zone. So all of it translates well into how and why I've been the Special Master of the September 11th Victim Compensation Fund for the last 3½ years.

We want as many people as possible to know, one, we're still here. We are in business until 2090. We have as much funding as is necessary to pay every eligible claimant. And two, we serve people beyond first responders. We serve people that lived, worked, went to school in the New York exposure zone, who were at Shanksville and at the Pentagon. We really encourage people if they were there, to register with the VCF. In order to file a claim, folks need to get certified that they have a 9/11 illness from the World Trade Center Health Program, which is our sister program that runs out of HHS. We are receiving over 700 new claims a month.

Since 2011, when we reopened, we have received over 110,000 claims. We've paid out $18.5 billion compensation. [The original VCF closed in 2004 after paying out the $7 billion appropriated for those killed or physically injured on 9/11.] The CDC estimates that in New York alone, over 400,000 people may have been exposed to the toxins.

Remember "America Strong"? "Let everybody return"? "Let's begin to live, work, go to school, start over again"? People went back into the New York zone, and the consequence, of course, is they were exposed to these toxins that have made them ill. And people have died from it. On that day, 2,977 people perished at all three sites and on the planes. Since we reopened, we've had 6,100 of our claimants die from exposure to the toxins. And unfortunately, every year there are more people becoming ill. Today, 63% of our claimants have a cancer, and those cancers, because of the unique nature of what people were exposed to, may have long latency periods.

Every Sept. 11, the memorial and museum in New York City does the reading of the names of the victims, and there's always six moments of silence, to mark the four moments of impact and two tower collapses. This year, they're adding a seventh, to honor the people that have become ill from the toxins. I think that'll help spread awareness that so many are still suffering and that the 9/11 VCF is here to help.

Christopher Ashley

Courtesy Photo

I actually didn't behave that great that day. I almost got into a fistfight.

It was the first day of rehearsal for the play *Wonder of the World*, which I was directing. We canceled rehearsal for that day and the next, and I ended up walking back home to the West Village. Late that night, there was a very drunk man who put himself in front of me and asked if I was an Iraqi. He kept putting himself in front of me, and I kept trying to get away. Then he took a swing at me, and I punched him in the face.

It’s not automatic that people are their best selves in these moments. I think one of the things people do with traumatic situations is move on, so it was really meaningful to me to dig back into the feelings that that day created while directing *Come From Away*, a musical about 38 planes grounded in Gander, Newfoundland, and the people who took care of strangers at this moment of real terror. Telling that story around the world, onstage, on Apple TV helped me heal.

In 2011, the play’s authors, David Hein and Irene Sankoff, went to a 10th anniversary event reconvening a lot of the people who had been diverted there on 9/11. They expected to be there for a couple of days and ended up staying for weeks and weeks. Claude Elliott, the mayor of Gander, used to joke, "Wait, you guys are making a musical about making sandwiches?”

In the current world we're living in, it almost seems mythical that people would take this good care of each other because there are just so many things that pull us apart and make us suspicious of each other. We're all vulnerable. Nobody’s safely apart behind a wall. We're all going to have to figure out how to share the world and the space together. The world keeps changing, but the show remains about the responsibility we have to each other and the value of kindness and connection. Twenty-five years ago, if more people thought like the people in Gander—“these people are my problem, my responsibility, and I will take care of them, despite the fact that I didn't meet them until today”—I think we'd be in a better place. *–As told to O.B.W.*

Nancy Gibbs

Elizabeth D. Herman for TIME

Moments after 8:46 a.m., attention fixed on one incomprehensible event. As first responders scrambled and survivors fled, the rest of us skidded to a stop and watched.

At TIME, editor Jim Kelly launched a reporting army: correspondents around the world tracked the attacks and reactions in real time. White House correspondent Jay Carney was with President Bush in the press pool; writers and editors in the New York City headquarters headed downtown, or to city hospitals and command centers. My job was to curate and condense it all into a single story for a special issue of the magazine. “I just want you to tell the story of today,” Jim told me. “Think of it as a time capsule.”

In one sense we all saw something different. If you lived in New York City, not only did you see the smoke, you smelled it, tasted it. You heard the sirens, felt the fear. Elsewhere, the alerts jolted large towns and small. Local landmarks shivered and then shut down: Disney World and the Sears Tower, Congress and the Supreme Court, the Space Needle. Also, the entire airspace of the United States.

But at a deeper level, we all saw the same thing, a once unimaginable attack on what we soon started calling the Homeland,

as though we were all residents of the same reality. No matter how different our individual experiences of that day, we lived through it together and emerged more united: By October, 60% of people said they trusted the government to do the right thing all or most of the time, a three-decade high.

It's easier to put a jigsaw puzzle together when you can see the whole picture on the lid of the box. Yes, there were toxic rumors and conspiracies even without the yet-to-be-invented Facebook and X. But compared with what has transpired since then, the information landscape looks practically pristine. The demolition of the business model for traditional news sources corresponded with sinking institutional trust across the board. Journalism's self-inflicted wounds and technological upheaval radically changed how people make sense of the world. Trust in government now sits around 17%. Trust in the media has hit an all-time low.

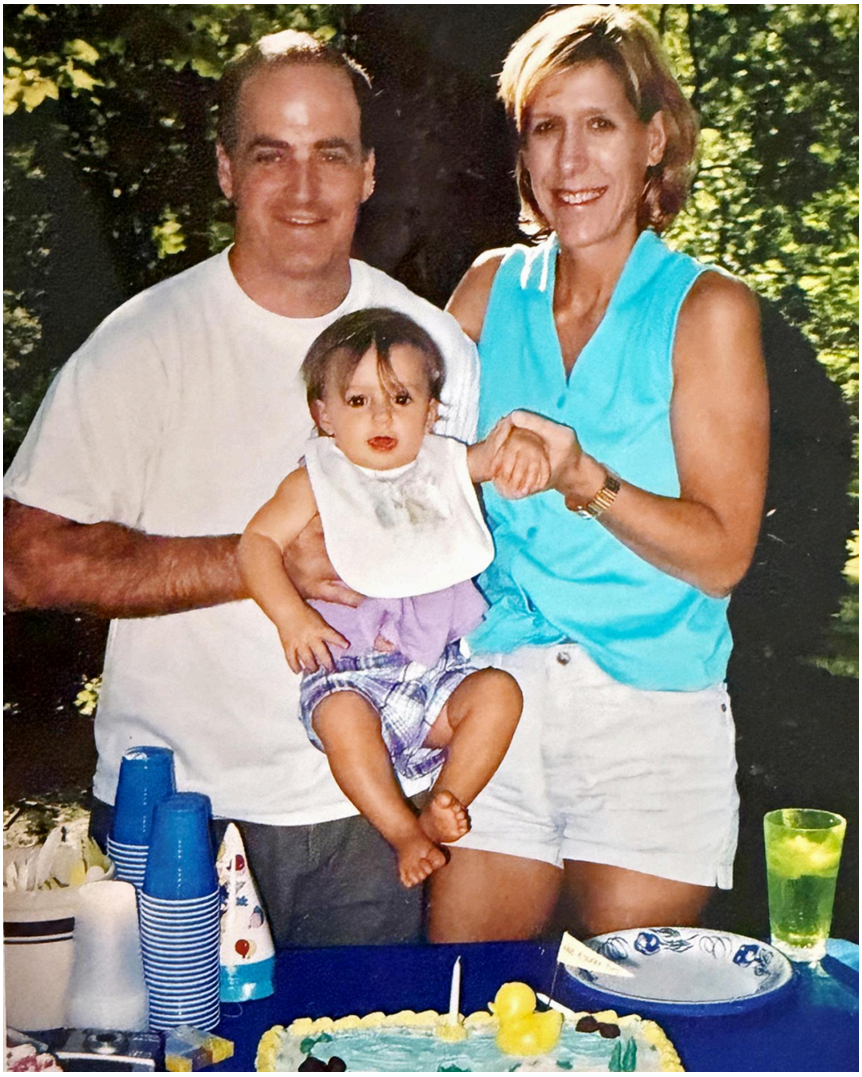
If you had told me 25 years ago, as we color-coded the threat level, cast a wide surveillance net, launched a Global War on Terror, that we would manage to avoid further terror attacks, I would have found it hard to believe. But I also couldn't have imagined the maceration of the media as our news channels filled with content of all kinds streaming in from all corners. This year for the first time, more people globally rely on social and video platforms for news, rather than TV or news websites. As audiences migrate from broadcast and cable, print and radio, to creators on TikTok and YouTube, the very notion of a shared reality feels quaint. Eight in 10 of us say Democrats and Republicans can't even agree on basic facts, which makes reasoned discussion of everything from security threats to education reform all but impossible.

Twenty-five years ago, like journalists everywhere, I focused on how to tell this story, in the belief that stories are stickier than bloodless fact. But what has happened since makes me wonder if I missed the actual war. Sept. 11 did not cause 21st century truth decay, but it coincided with it. Jolted out of the snug 1990s, people

went searching for answers they could trust, tribes they could join, distraction as an antidote to alarm. We no longer hear the same stories and too many leaders are counting on that. We can each collect the puzzle pieces, but it's harder to see the full picture. Even when the country is broadly united around key values—reject political violence, protect the safety net, get money out of politics, regulate AI—the sense of division abides and people on both sides see mainly a caricature of their opponents.

Strong societies need good information; communities benefit from shared stories. On Sept. 11, many of those stories were of quiet, reflexive heroism, sacrifice, service. First responders and random strangers modeled courage under fire, and the rest of us were swept up in a wave of gratitude that helped drain the fear. Those are stories worth retrieving now. –*Nancy Gibbs*

Keira Unterzuber, Eric Johnson, and Freya Johnson



Courtesy Photo

Keira: My first child was due on Sept. 3, and my doctor was going to induce me on the 13th. So the 11th was any other day, really. I was getting ready for work when my husband, who is a pilot and was home on family leave, said, “Keira, come here.” He explained that a plane had crashed in the World Trade Center, and I said, “But it's so sunny!” He's like, “Yeah, that's really weird.” And while we were watching the TV, the second plane hit. As the morning went on, I started to feel unwell. But then I don’t think anybody felt well that day.

Eric: We live near the Pentagon, and suddenly, it was like somebody pushed over a piano in the room next to us. It shook the whole house. The cats jumped off the bed and hid. I went outside

and saw smoke. Sometime in there, Keira said, “I’m having the baby today.” I drove 80 to 90 miles an hour all the way to the hospital. There was zero traffic. It was eerie, like driving somewhere in the middle of the night.

Keira: Because of construction, we had to go through the emergency-room entrance and I remember all these emergency medical staff just waiting, and not for me. In the delivery room, Eric started to say he was ready to join the military and go fight the terrorists and because of the mood that he was in, he suggested several new names for the baby: Phoenix, America, Freedom, Liberty. I just said no, no, no. Eventually he picked Freya, who is goddess of war and love and a very strong woman.

Freya: When I was young, I didn’t really understand the significance of the day. But around the 10th anniversary, I realized, “Oh, this is huge,” and then it became very depressing. On the morning announcements at school, they’d show a video tribute, and those videos were obviously very sad. In middle school, some kid told me that I was the reincarnation of Osama bin Laden. So I used to wish I was born on the 10th or the 12th. I actually didn’t celebrate my birthday from ages 10 to 13. It just felt inappropriate and weird to be so happy when everyone else was not. I can’t tell you how many times I’ve told people my birthday, and it becomes a whole conversation. When I need ID at a bar or when I have to pick up a prescription, and they ask me for my birthday, they’re like, “Really?” I’ve even had people ask me, “What was that like for you?” And I have to say, “Well, I was not even born yet so I was not aware of anything.” I’ve learned to just say my birthday is in September. However, as I’ve gotten older, I’ve realized that I like my birthday. It’s such a beautiful time of year. I’m at the point where I can acknowledge that it was sad, but I can also celebrate myself. All my friends tell me that when they think of 9/11, they think of me as their first thought.

Keira: When something tragic happens, it’s a beautiful thing to be around a newborn baby. My brother’s wife lost her first husband on the 10th, and his funeral was on the 13th. She adores Freya because, in her world, she’s a bright light at a dark moment. We have a lot of friends who say that year after year: She was the shining light that day. *–As told to B.L.*

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https://time.com/article/2026/09/03/how-9-11-shaped-my-life/

https://time.com/collection/latino-leaders/2026/

World

- **Merz Under Pressure After Far-Right Party Emerges Victorious in State Election**
  The Alternative for Germany result is the closest a far-right party has come to holding power at state level in Germany since World War II.
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Merz Under Pressure After Far-Right Party Emerges Victorious in State Election

Ulrich Siegmund, leader of the Alternative for Germany (AfD) party in the eastern state of Saxony-Anhalt, speaks on stage with AfD co-leader Alice Weidel at the party headquarters following the Saxony-Anhalt regional elections in Magdeburg, Germany, on Sept. 6, 2026.Krisztian Bocsi—Bloomberg/Getty Images

German Chancellor Friedrich Merz's party on Monday ruled out working with Alternative for Germany (AfD), a day after suffering a defeat in the eastern state of Saxony-Anhalt.

The far-right AfD won 43.8% of the vote in Saxony-Anhalt's state election on Sunday, according to exit polls. Merz's center-right Christian Democratic Union (CDU) secured 17.2% of the vote. Despite its commanding victory, the AfD fell three seats short of a majority in the state legislature. AfD had been aiming for an absolute majority to govern alone and overcome the "firewall" of the mainstream political establishment's refusal to work with the party.

The result has presented a new test for the so-called firewall, underscoring the falling popularity of Merz and AfD's growing national strength.

"This election has further weakened the unpopular Merz. He was unable to fulfill his promise to significantly weaken the AfD," Benjamin Höhne, a professor of comparative European governance systems at Chemnitz University of Technology, tells TIME. "The CDU in Saxony-Anhalt had already distanced itself from Merz during the campaign. This [result] is particularly dramatic given that, for many, Merz was seen as a beacon of hope as Merkel's successor."

Merz referred to the result as "the hardest defeat that the CDU has had for decades," at a press conference in Berlin.

The Chancellor tried to ease concerns over the stability of democratic institutions in Germany, as the AfD's victory puts them a step closer to governing at the regional level, something no far-right party in the country has achieved since World War II.

"I can reassure you: our institutions are stable, and our basic law protects this order, and the federal government, led by me, will make sure that the basic law is going to be enforced," Merz continued. "This message also goes out to our friends in Europe, as we know that Germany has a special responsibility because of its history."

The AfD's national co-leader Tino Chrupalla has appealed to CDU lawmakers to make a "center-right conservative majority" in Saxony-Anhalt a reality, telling a German radio station that "partisan games really ought to be a thing of the past."

Despite the AfD's uncertain path, the surge in support for the far-right party—which ran on a platform of restricting immigration, ending aid to Ukraine, and floated the possibility of taking

Germany out of the E.U.—is remarkable in a country where the legacy of Nazism has long kept the far right at the political margins. The party's Saxony-Anhalt branch is classified by the state's domestic intelligence as "right-wing extremist," a designation that its leaders reject.

"We have made history in this country," said Ulrich Siegmund, AfD's lead candidate in Saxony-Anhalt, after polls closed. "We're taking our country back, it starts in Saxony-Anhalt. A jolt is going through all of Germany."

According to an analysis by Infratest Dimap, the AfD vote swept across almost all age groups, except in the over-70 category, which saw 32% vote for AfD and 31% vote for CDU. The result was more divided across gender lines, with 50% of men backing the AfD, while only 39% of women voted for the far-right party

The state election result has drawn reactions from across the globe.

U.S. President Donald Trump posted a screenshot of the projected results without comment on Truth Social. Members of Trump's Administration, including Vice President J.D. Vance, have previously expressed public support for the party.

Tech billionaire Elon Musk, who spoke at AfD's campaign launch last year, congratulated AfD co-leader Alice Weidel on the victory. In response, Siegmund thanked him for his "support" and said he would "welcome the opportunity for strong and constructive cooperation."

Kirill Dmitriev, an envoy for Russian President Vladimir Putin who handles informal negotiations with the White House, argued that "AfD will restore Germany and Europe by leading the common-sense approach that migrant-friendly, warmongering Biden-think E.U. politicians tried to eradicate."

Europeans split over far-right AfD's victory as experts mull impact

The victory of the far-right AfD party has divided European officials.

Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez framed the result in Saxony-Anhalt as a “warning that the far-right threat, thanks largely to the surrender of the traditional right, is gaining ground in Europe and around the world."

French Member of the European Parliament (MEP) Valérie Hayer said AfD’s win “should serve as a wake-up call” for Europe.

“Europeans are turning more and more each day toward populist forces based on clearly identified issues,” she said. “Faced with the radicalism of the extremes, I am deeply convinced that we must counter with another kind of radicalism—one that is pro-European.”

France’s Europe minister Benjamin Haddad said the win was a “grave moment in Europe,” while Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk insisted “in Poland, only idiots or traitors can rejoice at the triumph of the AfD in Germany.”

Others across Europe welcomed waking up to the news from Germany.

Former Hungarian Prime Minister and Trump-ally Viktor Orbán said the result was a “huge night for Germany and Europe" and told everyone to “buckle up, this is just the beginning.”

Remarking on the impact for Europe, experts tell TIME that success in regional elections is often just the first step.

“There has been an increasing trend for the far right to do well. They start doing really well in the local elections, and then, slowly, they become more embedded, more legitimate,” Daphne Halikiopoulou, chair of comparative politics at the University of York, tells TIME.

Halikiopoulou points to other upcoming elections in other European countries like France, where far-right candidates currently show a lead ahead of the 2027 presidential contest, as ones to watch.

What to know about Siegmund and the AfD

The AfD’s platform in Saxony-Anhalt ranges from tighter immigration controls to a sweeping overhaul of the state’s education system. Among its more controversial proposals is a policy of “remigration,” which is widely interpreted as mass deportation, although the party says it will prioritize deporting people with a criminal record. It has also called for segregating children of refugees and asylum-seekers in schools, and ending war refugee status for Ukrainians fleeing the war with Russia.

The party would largely be unable to enact many of its immigration policies in any individual state even if it can form a government, since many of its proposals would require federal action. But it could tighten policing and pursue changes to schools and cultural policy at the state level.

The party wants to steer schools and cultural institutions towards more traditional and nationalist values. It has also advocated revising history curricula to shift emphasis away from the Third Reich and for schools to ban rainbow flags. Instead, it wants schools to fly the German national flag daily, sing the national anthem at school celebrations, and teach more Russian language.

The AfD has also attacked Bauhaus, calling the influential school and design movement an “aberration of modernism.” Critics, including Germany’s Culture Minister, have said the AfD’s rhetoric echoes that of the Nazis, who forced the Bauhaus school to close in 1933.

Other proposals include establishing citizen patrols and imposing a moratorium on new wind farms.

The AfD capitalized on disillusionment with the political establishment and drew on regional and national pride, including “Ostalgie” or nostalgia for aspects of life in the former communist East Germany. That message found fertile ground in eastern strongholds, like Saxony-Anhalt, where economic disparities with western Germany persist decades after reunification. During the campaign, Siegmund frequently rode a blue Simson, a moped manufactured in the former East Germany, a move that drew criticism from the descendants of the Jewish family that founded Simson.

The Halle Institute for Economic Research in Germany has warned that the AfD’s anti-immigration policies could deepen Saxony-Anhalt’s labor shortage and cost the state billions in economic output. Merz has also argued that an AfD victory could turn away foreign investment from the state.

Founded in 2013, support for the AfD has grown significantly in recent years.

The AfD doubled its national vote share in 2025, and is the country’s most popular party nationally, polling at 28%, according to a recent INSA poll. At the same time, support for the federal government led by Merz, which is struggling to revive a sluggish economy, has fallen to historic lows. In the same INSA poll, Merz’s conservative party had 20% support. In Saxony-Anhalt, 87% of

voters were dissatisfied with the federal government, according to an ARD poll.

Siegmund has said he wants to become state premier and eventually bring the AfD to victory in the 2029 national elections.

What the results mean for the AfD

While the election delivered the AfD a commanding victory, the party still lacks enough votes to govern alone. With 39 seats in the 83-member legislature, the party remains three short of an outright majority, and faces no obvious path to obtaining it.

Germany's established parties have long refused to work with the AfD, continuing their firewall against cooperating with the far-right. State premier Sven Schulze acknowledged defeat but his party, the CDU, said it would explore talks with other parties about forming a multiparty coalition.

The AfD could find unlikely support in the populist Sahra Wagenknecht Alliance, or BSW, which scraped into parliament with 5.3% of the vote. BSW has rejected the firewall and expressed a willingness to speak with the AfD, although it said it would not elect either Siegmund or Schulze as premier.

Siegmund has thus far ruled out leading a minority government or adopting an informal arrangement that would leave his government depending on unsteady support. "If necessary there'll just be new elections, then we'd just get 50 or 55%," he told ZDF on election night. He said, however, that he would be willing to work with individual lawmakers or parliamentary groups.

Thousands joined an anti-AfD demonstration on Saturday in the regional capital of Magdeburg. Some carried banners that read, "life is better without Nazis." One protester, Laura Saalfeld, told

AFP, “Whatever the results, the atmosphere will change. Far-right sympathisers will show themselves more openly on the streets.”

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https://time.com/article/2026/09/07/germany-saxony-anhalt-election-afd-party-far-right-ulrich-siegmund/

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The World's Best Companies of 2026

Photo-illustration by TIME; Getty Images

Story

by

Charlotte Hu

Photo-illustration by TIME; Getty Images

The economy built around AI has continued to boom even as experts and leaders work to hammer out the technology's execution

problem and debate the guardrails that should be put around it. Demand for AI chips remains strong, as Nvidia holds its top spot in TIME and Statista's 2026 statistical ranking of the World's Best Companies, highlighting top performing companies around the globe based on evaluations of employee satisfaction, revenue growth, and sustainability transparency. But new companies are also entering the scene as the AI boom reaches down the supply chain.

Methodology: How TIME and Statista Determined the World's Best Companies of 2026

Companies like Wistron (no. 16), Lenovo (no. 51) and Zurich Insurance Group (no. 70) are new additions to the 2026 list. Major Nvidia supplier Wistron reports that the demand for its AI servers continues to exceed supply. The Taiwan-based manufacturing company recently opened a plant in Texas to ramp up production. Chinese computer company Lenovo, known for being a maker of devices like PCs, smartphones and tablets, saw annual profits rise to record sales driven by the newer AI server part of their business. And the wave of growing demand for physical infrastructure to support AI has created an opportunity for firms like Zurich Insurance Group to cash in on selling more data center construction-related insurance. Zurich plans to expand its dedicated insurance and risk management solution for large-scale data center projects soon into Europe and Latin America. S&P Global puts total insurable values for each data center at up to $30 billion per location.

Beyond AI, European defense technology companies are seeing cashflow as a result of European NATO allies committing in 2025 to spend a projected €800 billion on defense readiness by 2030. "The increased defense spending in Europe is actually one of the largest demand signals we have seen in generations," says Hugues Lavandier, senior partner in McKinsey's Aerospace & Defense Practice. A good portion of that spending is still going outside of

Europe, but Lavandier “won't be surprised that we increasingly see more of that spend going to Europe for sovereignty reasons.” The war in Ukraine among other recent geopolitical tensions has shown Europe that the art of war fighting and the equipment needed is also changing. “The share of that money being spent on equipment is actually going up,” Lavandier says, especially on new technologies like drones and unmanned vehicles, and addressing technical challenges like navigation, electronic warfare, intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance.

Traditional companies in the space like French defense electronics maker Thales (no. 22; up from no. 224 in 2025) and Italian defense and aerospace company Leonardo (no. 25; up from a no. 126 in 2025) are seeing uptick in orders. At the same time, “non-traditional players are entering into the field, especially as suppliers,” Lavandier says. “In particular, a number of automotive players have entered into the fray…sometimes even selling plants, making capacity available.” Thales, for example, recently announced a sovereign drone partnership with French carmaker Renault (no. 42). A number of new startups are also taking this opportunity to translate the investment into innovations, sometimes as standalone products or in partnership with other companies, similar to Anduril’s ventures in the U.S. For example, German drone-maker Quantum Systems, which is currently supplying armed forces in Ukraine, announced significant investment from German telecomm giant Deutsche Telekom (no. 7), which owns the T-mobile brand, and also announced a new partnership with Rheinmetall (no. 287) to co-create an anti-drone shield.

See the full list of the World’s Best Companies of 2026 below:

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https://time.com/article/2026/09/09/worlds-best-companies-of-2026/

Others

- **Amy Sherald - TIME100 Art 2026**
  From painting Michelle Obama's portrait to pulling out of a Smithsonian solo show, Amy Sherald reflects on the art and trials that shaped her.
- **How Zoe Kazan MadeEast of EdenHer Own**
  The writer discusses adapting the novel Elia Kazan made into a classic movie, centering Cathy's story, and that Taylor Swift tweet

Amy Sherald Would Rather Walk Away Than Water Down Her Art

People painter

Photograph by Tyler Mitchell for TIME

Nobody knows in advance the moment that will change everything, but some of Amy Sherald's friends sensed something was up. The artist had been called to meet Barack and Michelle Obama as they decided who would paint their official portraits. Her best friend's mother insisted on taking her to MaxMara and buying her a taupe sheath and kitten heels. When she walked into the Oval Office, both the President and the First Lady were wearing the same color. The President quipped that she must have gotten the memo. Sherald did not get the joke. But she did get the job that changed her life: the portrait of Michelle Obama that is the highlight of "American Sublime," the blockbuster show of Sherald's work that is just finishing an almost two-year, four-museum national tour.

Photograph by Tyler Mitchell for TIME

Color has always been important to Sherald, as anyone with even a brief acquaintance with her paintings can tell. She paints all her canvases red before she paints them gray. “I think color lives whether you can see it or not,” she says in her Jersey City, N.J., studio, a few feet from a giant pegboard filled with hundreds of paint tubes held up by bulldog clips. “So I consider the red kind of like the blood behind the figures there.” Maybe that’s why, even though she paints everyone in gray tones, Sherald’s people pulse with life. Sometimes they float off dirt bikes, or balance on tractors, or hold a doll or a baby or an outsize teacup, but mostly they command attention, looking evenly at the viewer, wearing bright clothes in front of a vivid background. “Color is my natural

language," says Sherald, 53. "Using my voice is only the third best way that I communicate."

Her inspirations for the color and the composition of her work come from paintings, she says. But the subject matter is mostly inspired by photography, because that is what she grew up seeing, in family portraits and encyclopedias. Once she finds a subject, she photographs them in an outfit she has preselected. Often the clothing is the starting point. (She's in the early stages of a work inspired by a vintage Girl Scouts uniform.) Despite her most famous painting, she doesn't call herself a portraitist. "Once I take the photograph, the model just becomes a character in the world that I'm trying to create," she says. "This is now a part of this greater picture and this greater story."

Photograph by Tyler Mitchell for TIME

Successful artists are the product of their gifts, but as Sherald proves, they are also products of what they lacked. Sherald grew up in a home that followed the teachings of the Worldwide Church of God, which did not celebrate, among other things, birthdays, Halloween, movies, most dancing, and TV. Her home kept a Sabbath on Saturdays. Not that Sherald minded. “For me as a child who was self-conscious and introverted, I would choose to stay in and draw rather than go outside,” she says. “It was like a safe way to play that was not with other people.” Her father, a dentist, was diagnosed with Parkinson's when she was 7. She would often just sit with him. “When you have a parent that doesn't communicate well and they're also going through something they want to hide

from you, it kind of opens up another way of learning about emotion and communication."

Famously, it was on a school trip that Sherald saw Bo Bartlett's painting *Object Permanence*, centered on a Black man in a tool belt, which inspired her to depict Black people as she saw them. "It was just about looking. Looking back at our history and painting the things that I didn't see," she says. "Art history tells me that I'm elevating my people, but I'm not. That's just the story that's projected onto my storytelling. They're already there." She and Bartlett are now friends.

Recognition for Sherald's work came slowly, then all at once. Just before she had her heart transplant, at 39, after she stopped waitressing to look after her brother, she sold a painting for $3,000. Her friends set up a GoFundMe page for her medical costs. "I'm sure some people were like, 'Poor Amy, she wants to be an artist,'" she says. "'She's still working at this restaurant, like it's obvious it's not gonna happen.'" In 2019, a year after the Obama portrait was unveiled, her work *Innocent You, Innocent Me* sold for $350,000 at Christie's. A mere 18 months later, *The Bathers* netted $4.26 million at auction. She found the sudden uptick in wealth and fame difficult. "People don't think you've earned it," she says. "And there's pressure to do more because you have this success."

The heart transplant has made Sherald, who has books about overcoming anxiety in her office, even more cautious. She wanted to take up cycling but realized a fall could hurt her hand. She no longer rides roller coasters. She lost her father when she was 27 and brother to lung cancer when he was 38. Her sister also recently had a heart transplant. But if those health crises have made her wary, they did not make her scared. In 2025, after officials at the Smithsonian's National Portrait Gallery, the same institution that commissioned the Obama portrait, got skittish about exhibiting her painting *Trans Forming Liberty,* which features a trans woman, she pulled the show. "'American Sublime' has its own narrative," she

says. “Deviating from that narrative would be deviating from the core person of who I am and why the work exists in the world, and I just wasn't willing to do that.” The exhibition was snapped up by the Baltimore Museum of Art, where it broke attendance records.

Photograph by Tyler Mitchell for TIME

Sherald, to quote the old gospel song, wouldn’t take nothing for her journey now. “There's only one person I've ever been envious of in my life, and that was Oprah Winfrey when she was giving away cars to people,” she says. “I want to be able to do that. I want someone to give me enough money that I can set up a big foundation where there's rolling grants for artists for medical care, for housing, for studios. Because that's all we need to become who we want to be: time and money.” In the meantime, she’s delighted

by the life she has been given. “I think,” she says, “art definitely chose me.”

Set by Nicole Roosien; Hair by Nikki Nelms at The Only Agency; Makeup by Joseph Carrillo; Styling: Law Roach at The Only Agency; Cover look: Bora Aksu; Studio environmental: Erdem; Blue background: JW Anderson; Videos: Roksanda dress, Alexis Bittar jewels.

TIME100 Art | Amy Sherald

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https://time.com/collection/time100-art/2026/amy-sherald/

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How Zoe Kazan Made *East of Eden* Her Own

Zoe KazanRuvèn Afanador—Netflix

In June 2024, Zoe Kazan boarded a flight to New Zealand. She was excited. For a mother of small children, a quiet solo flight is a vacation unto itself. She scrolled through the in-flight movies. “They had *East of Eden*, and I was like, ‘I guess the gods are conspiring,’” she says. She pressed play.

Until then she had been avoiding rewatching her grandfather Elia Kazan’s 1955 masterpiece. She was flying halfway across the world to scout locations for her own version of *East of Eden*, a seven-part adaptation of John Steinbeck’s novel that premieres on

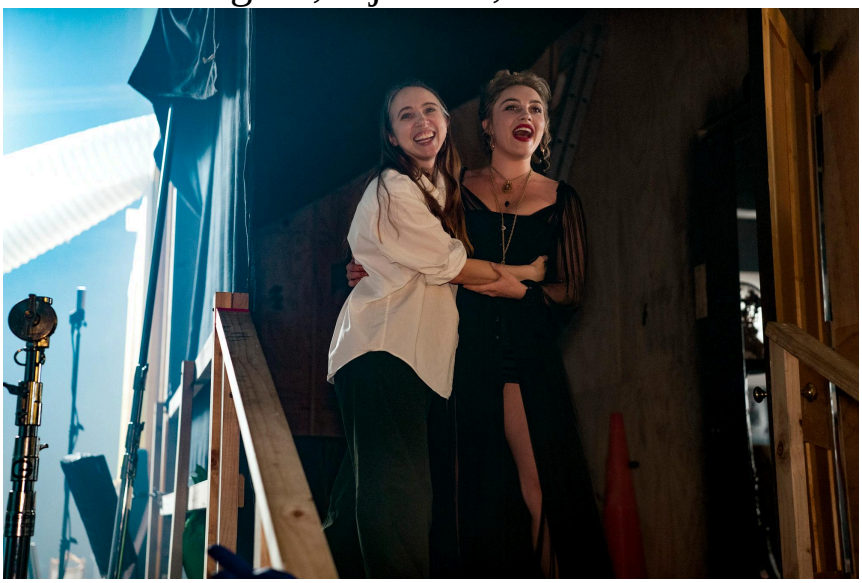
Netflix on Oct. 1. She hadn't wanted the film to influence her. But her script, which she'd begun working on in 2020, was finally turned in.

As the end credits rolled, she sighed in relief. "It was less like the book than I remembered," she says. The film, which introduced a brooding James Dean to cinema, is more inspired by the novel than a direct adaptation of it: It covers only the last third, crucial characters have been excised, and famous lines are missing. "For me," says Kazan over cold brew, extra ice on the side, at a Brooklyn cafe on an August morning, "the power of the story is how, over 50 years, it shows history repeating itself—or not."

Her faithful adaptation covers the entirety of the multi-generational saga, which reimagines the tale of Cain and Abel twice over. Cyrus (Tracy Letts in the new series), a self-mythologizing Civil War veteran, prefers his gentle son Adam (Christopher Abbott) to the violent one, Charles (Mike Faist). A generation later, Adam's twin sons Aron and Cal (Joe Anders and Joseph Zada) vie for the affection of their emotionally absent father. Kazan wrangles with the novel's central question: Whether those boys can escape the shadows of their family history and forge their own paths—and whether America, carrying the sins of slavery, campaigns of violence against Native Americans, and racism against immigrants building a future in the West, can do the same.

Both versions are, in Kazan's estimation, self-portraits of the artists who made them. Renowned for directing *A Streetcar Named Desire* and *On the Waterfront* and co-founding the influential Actors Studio from which the school of "method acting" was born, Elia Kazan was called before the House Un-American Activities Committee in 1952. The Hollywood blacklist was in effect and, Faced with the possibility of never being able to work in Hollywood again, he named names. His granddaughter has never read his autobiography, though she has tried. "There's some very young part of me that's like, I still want my grandpa to be my

grandpa and not have access to all of this adult stuff," she says. But she believes that Elia Kazan, who died in 2003 when she was 20, saw himself in the black sheep of the family: "He had this cold and demanding father, and I think he was projecting onto Cal." Made during a period when the director was facing significant backlash, his version focuses on guilt, rejection, and alienation.



Writer Zoe Kazan and her star Florence Pugh on the set of Netflix's East of EdenGeoffrey Short—Netflix

What most intrigued Zoe Kazan, a new mother when she started on the script, were characters her grandfather rewrote or omitted: Cathy (Florence Pugh), a mother who walks out on her infant sons and whom Kazan calls "irredeemable, irresistible, and so full of agency," and Lee (Hoon Lee), a Chinese American servant who steps in to raise the boys.

Kazan may live closest to Cathy and Lee in her script. But perhaps the reason she was drawn to the project is the notion of living and working in her grandfather's shadow. One cannot help but draw the parallel between her and the grandchildren in *East of Eden*, struggling with whether to embrace or break away from a burdensome legacy. "The irony was not lost on me. There's a literal way that I'm following in my family's footsteps," Kazan admits. "I don't think I'd be doing my job as an artist if I weren't thinking about my family while making this family story."

Zoe Kazan was a teenager when she fell hard for Steinbeck. At 15, the Los Angeles native embarked on a Steinbeck-themed road trip up the California coast with her parents, dog-eared *East of Eden* in hand. Years later, she asked her agents to contact her if anyone purchased the rights. The call came in December 2019, while Kazan was shooting in Australia. She emerged bleary-eyed from a flight back to L.A. with her 15-month-old to pitch her idea to the buyers. “I talked about America and the way that we don’t want to look at our shadow, and how the book argues that embracing your shadow, all of yourself, the good and the bad, is the only way to change,” she says.

By then she had built a career not just as an actor in *The Big Sick* and *She Said* but as a screenwriter with *Ruby Sparks*, a satirical take on the manic pixie dream girl, and *Wildlife*, a drama she co-wrote with her partner, Paul Dano. She landed the *East of Eden* job and spent the next six years in Steinbeck’s world, and much of that time in the head of one of literature’s most complicated female characters, Cathy.

Cathy appears mysteriously on Adam and Charles’ doorstep, badly beaten. From there, she vacillates between a mesmerizing seductress and evil incarnate. She’s a manipulator or a survivor, depending on your perspective. “I don’t think anything in her background excuses her behavior,” says Kazan, laughing. “At the same time, there’s something really compelling about her insistence on her autonomy and selfishness, especially as a woman. I was such a good girl, reading that felt very exciting.”

Mike Faist, Christopher Abbott, and Florence Pugh in Netflix's East of EdenNetflix

Cathy became the center of Kazan's adaptation. Often accused by the narrator of being a liar, Cathy in fact often tells the truth. It's just not a truth the men around her want to hear. She says she does not want to move to California. She says does not want kids. She says she does not want to stay once Cal and Aron are born. Today's readers may be appalled by the way she earns her freedom, but we can also sympathize with a woman whose wishes are so blatantly ignored.

Not even Steinbeck could decide. In letters to his editor, "He starts out like, 'You've never read a monster like this,'" says Kazan. "Then he starts referring to her like, 'I'll finally get back to my dear Cathy.' He seems very seduced by her." Kazan relied heavily on the book to flesh Cathy out. This is not some girlboss version of one of literature's great antagonists. "I think the text supports my reading," she says. "I don't like historical fiction that imposes modern values on the past. I don't think Cathy is a feminist. I don't think she cares about other women. I think she cares about herself."

Pugh was the only actor Kazan named in her script. She's made an career of morally complex characters in *Lady Macbeth*, *Midsommar*, and even the Marvel movies. As Cathy, she's transfixing. "Florence looks like a doll, but she has this steel rod

inside,” says Kazan. “Cathy is all action, like a shark that always has to be moving forward.”

East of Eden has aged so well in some respects that Kazan might get accused of making modern updates by those who haven’t read the text. After Cathy leaves Adam, the story centers on two men, Adam and Lee, platonically raising a family and navigating the complicated gender-role implications of that arrangement.

Lee’s parents were brought from China to build the railroads. He spends his life being the smartest man in any room but feigning broken English to make the white men around him comfortable, only revealing his intellect to those he trusts. For a few chapters, Lee departs for San Francisco to pursue the dream of opening his own bookstore. He returns with little to say about what happened while he was gone. "Even though [Steinbeck] imagines things like Lee code-switching, which is such a shocking thing to read in this book from 1952, I felt like it was this mystery of what happens to Lee when he goes away,” says Kazan. “I wanted to give him a little bit more." Kazan brought in the novelist Alexander Chee to build out the scenes for Lee that Steinbeck left off the page.

She wrote eight episodes, including one exclusively following Lee on his San Francisco excursion. Netflix greenlit seven. "It was the obvious stuff that had to go, partially because it's off the main track of the story, but also because it's all new locations. It would have added a third to our budget,” she says. She had to weave the plot into another episode. “I was so sad to lose that episode, but I do think it's stronger for it, because he's not siloed. He's part of the cohesive story."

Hoon Lee in Netflix's East of EdenNetflix

When Adam checks out psychologically for the better part of a decade, Lee raises Cal and Aron, deliberately trying to prevent in this new generation the fractures and violence of the previous one. Steinbeck's narrator observes Lee's domestic and emotional work with admiration and grants Lee an unexpected dignity given the time period. The Netflix series doubles down, lingering on Lee's face to capture a flicker of resigned sorrow at moments when Adam claims ownership over the boys and their accomplishments.

"A lot of this caretaking, doing the invisible work, my experience of becoming a mother, is embedded in Lee," Kazan says. But so, too, is she Cathy. "There's also a part of me, as there is for many mothers, that's like, 'I love my children more than anything, and I wish I could disappear.'"

Early in our nearly two-hour conversation, Kazan asks a server to lower the music so we can dig our teeth into Lee's famous monologue on *timshel*, a Hebrew word that translates to "thou mayest" in the Cain and Abel story. It offers Cain and others the choice to triumph over sin. It frees younger generations from repeating the mistakes of their forebears. One can guess why this may ring true for Zoe Kazan. We circle the question of the divide

between an artist and their art as ice melts in her cup. I bring up a tweet she wrote over the summer.

When Taylor Swift got married in July and observers clocked the absence of a longtime friend from the wedding, Kazan posted her interpretation of the situation online: "I think she didn't invite *her* because she has come to the end of her marriage plot, thus cutting off access to her first great subject. Rather than root for her own divorce, she is generating the next chapter of interpersonal drama for herself via female friendship." The tweet read like a literary critic's interpretation of a pop star's public art. Swifties called it out of line. Kazan deleted it.

"When an artist makes her personal life the subject of her work, and has her wedding in one of our nation's foremost arenas with billboards outside saying 'Just Married,' I don't think it's a personal critique to talk about what they're doing in their personal life," she says. "I am very careful to be kind online. I never say anything mean about anyone's work. So I erased those tweets once I realized how upset people were by it. Should I have known better? Probably. But I had never been on the receiving end of Swifties before, so I didn't know."

I have spent much of the interview trying to divine how much of *East of Eden* is an extension of Kazan herself—she cites the *timshel* passage when referring to her relationship with her family's legacy. Viewers familiar with her history may theorize about her connection to the material in the same way that Kazan offered up a theory about Swift. "[Swift] puts the names of her exes in her liner notes. There's a way that she has made her private life incredibly public and explicit," she says. "The overlap with my personal history in this was all very conscious, and made more conscious the longer I worked on it. But it's not the explicit subject of it."

She hopes the story opens doors inside viewers, the way it did for her. "I think we have tendencies as humans to feel the weight of